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WEST BENGAL TURNS SAFFRON

SUVENDU ADHIKARI TAKES OATH AS CHIEF MINISTER, FIVE OTHERS SWORN-IN

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi/Kolkata

Suvendu Adhikari (52) was sworn in as the West Bengal Chief Minister on Saturday, becoming the first leader from the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) to hold the post since India's Independence. The grand ceremony held at historic Brigade Ground with thousands of boisterous party workers raising slogans marked the end of 15 years of Trinamool Congress (TMC) rule under Mamata Banerjee. For the people of West Bengal, the day marks not just a change of guard but the beginning of a new political era. It also signals a seismic shift in a State long dominated by regional parties.

The event unfolded five days after the BJP's landslide victory in the Assembly elections, where the party secured 207 seats, comfortably crossing the majority mark and ending TMC's long-standing grip on power. Adhikari, who was unanimously elected leader of the BJP Legislature Party, took the oath of office and secrecy first, administered by Governor RN Ravi. He was followed by senior BJP leader Dilip Ghosh and four other legislators: Agnimitra Paul, Ashok Kirtania, Kshudiram Tudu and Nisith Pramanik, who were inducted as ministers in the first cabinet of the new Government.

The swearing-in ceremony was attended by a galaxy of national and state leaders, underscoring the importance the BJP central leadership attaches to its maiden Government in Bengal. Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Union Home Minister Amit Shah, Chief Ministers of several BJP-ruled states, Union ministers and senior party functionaries flew in to

Prime Minister Narendra Modi with West Bengal chief minister-elect Suvendu Adhikari during the latter's oath-taking ceremony as party forms Government in the State for the first time at Brigade Parade Ground in Kolkata, West Bengal on Saturday

We will work with complete dedication to fulfill the aspirations of Ma, Mati, and Manush— SUVENDU ADHIKARI, CHIEF MINISTER

witness the historic transition. The presence of top leaders turned the occasion into a grand political spectacle, with thousands of supporters gathering outside the venue, waving saffron flags and chanting slogans of "Jai Shri Ram".

Adhikari has emerged as the face of the BJP's aggressive and high-decibel campaign that focused on issues of development, anti-incumbency against the TMC regime and promises of Double-Engine governance. He won convincingly from both the Bhabanipur and Nandigram constituencies, a rare feat that highlighted his personal popularity and organisational reach.

A heavyweight in West Bengal politics, Adhikari had been the Leader of Opposition in the outgoing Assembly and played a pivotal role in expanding the BJP's footprint in rural and semi-urban Bengal.

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PM bows, thanks voters

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

In a rare gesture to extend gratitude to the people of West Bengal for ensuring massive electoral success for the BJP's first Government in the State, Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Saturday bowed before the people of Bengal with folded hands as the party celebrated the swearing-in of its first chief minister at Kolkata's iconic Brigade Parade Ground.

"I bow to the Jana Shakti of West Bengal!" PM later remarked on social media and shared a video clip of the moment. As he walked up to the stage to witness the history in the making, Modi, dressed in his trademark kurta-jacket attire, bowed down before the attendees in a near—*dandwat pranam*, a gesture seen as one of humility, and respect towards the people for their mandate.

The Prime Minister humbly acknowledged people's power in a democracy that has thrived in India since Independence. Moreover, the gesture was a reflection of

I BOW TO THE JANA SHAKTI OF WEST BENGAL! THE PRIME MINISTER HUMBLY ACKNOWLEDGED PEOPLE'S POWER IN A DEMOCRACY THAT HAS THRIVED IN INDIA SINCE INDEPENDENCE

NARENDRA MODI, PRIME MINISTER

Modi's long-held position of himself as a servant of the people and not the ruler. Adhikari and members of the new cabinet stood beside the Prime Minister during the moment.

The PM began his long gesture of thanks by waving at the cheering crowds from a podium with red carpeting. Soon after Modi knelt down slowly and bowed before the crowds waving his hands to the massive crowd watching the oath taking ceremony.

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GREAT OFFERS!

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ED arrests Punjab minister Sanjeev Arora in GST fraud case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chandigarh

Punjab politics came to a boil on Saturday with Assembly elections less than a year away, when the Enforcement Directorate (ED) arrested Punjab Industries Minister Sanjeev Arora following raids in connection with an alleged ₹100 crore GST fraud-related money laundering case involving certain entities linked to him.

Following the arrest, AAP chief Arvind Kejriwal and Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann condemned the ED action, accusing the Centre of using agencies like the ED and the CBI as weapons to scare Opposition leaders into joining the BJP. But the BJP hit back, saying AAP supremo and his party are rattled as they know that their days are numbered in Punjab.

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Yogi likely to expand Cabinet today

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Lucknow

The Yogi Adityanath Cabinet 2.0 is likely to undergo expansion on Sunday evening. The move is seen as a significant political recalibration by the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) ahead of the 2027 UP Assembly elections.

The last Cabinet expansion of the Yogi Adityanath Government 2.0 was held on March 5, 2024. Four new ministers — Om Prakash Rajbhar (SBSP), Anil Kumar (RLD), Dara Singh Chauhan (BJP) and Sunil Kumar Sharma (BJP) to be were inducted.

The Yogi Adityanath headed Council of Ministers consists of 53 members, including the chief minister, two deputy chief ministers, 16 Cabinet ministers, 14 ministers of

State with independent charge, and 20 ministers of State. As per the provisions of the Constitution, there can be 60 ministers in council of ministers or 60 per cent of the strength of the State Assembly.

Following the Lok Sabha elections, Cabinet Minister Jitin Prasada and Minister of

State Anoop Pradhan Valmiki — both from UP — were elected as Members of Parliament. Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath met Uttar Pradesh Governor Anandiben Patel on Saturday.

Six ministers are likely to take oath, while the portfolios of several existing ministers could also be reshuffled. According to sources, at least six new faces are being considered for induction into the council of ministers. The names doing the rounds include Bhupendra Chaudhary, Manoj Pandey, Pooja Pal (both rebels from Samajwadi Party) Hansraj Vishwakarma and Krishna Paswan. Sources further indicated that one minister of state with independent charge could be elevated to the rank of Cabinet minister.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

Governor invites Vijay to form Govt

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chennai

After producing support letters, showing support of 120 MLAs, Governor RV Arlekar on Saturday appointed C Joseph Vijay as Chief Minister of Tamil Nadu, and the swearing-in ceremony will take place at Nehru Stadium on Sunday at 10 am. The Governor has asked TVK chief Vijay to prove a majority in three days.

Vijay was appointed CM after he presented letters of support from the VCK and the IUML, who have two MLAs each. The Governor held talks for about an hour over the requisite support. According to a Lok Bhavan press release, Vijay was appointed the chief minister by Governor Arlekar as per the provisions of the Constitution. The governor

Tamil Nadu Governor Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar hands over the letter of appointment to TVK chief C Joseph Vijay as the new State Chief Minister, at the Lok Bhavan, in Chennai on Saturday

also invited Vijay to form a ministry. Further, Arlekar asked Vijay to seek the vote of confidence on or before May 13.

The TVK chief met the Governor along with Congress PCC chief K Selvaperunthagai and

leaders of supporting parties, including the CPI(M) State Secretary P Shanmugam.

Taking into account support from VCK and IUML, who have 2 seats each, the TVK's seat tally has now touched 120 in the 234-member Assembly. VCK chief Thol

Thirumavalavan announced his party's decision to support Vijay's TVK in Government formation to prevent President's rule in Tamil Nadu and also ensure people's mandate for TVK was fulfilled.

Due to the prevailing uncertainty in Government formation, especially with the TVK lacking the simple majority to form the Government, and no other political party anywhere close to the magic number of 118 seats, it was necessary to support the TVK in its efforts to form the Government, Thirumavalavan said.

"Our ties with the DMK will not get affected due to our stand, but it will help Vijay to form the Government and also prevent the President's rule in the State," Thirumavalavan said at a crowded press conference.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

India tests advanced Agni missile from Odisha coast

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India on Saturday announced the successful flight-test of an Advanced Agni missile equipped with a Multiple Independently Targeted Re-Entry Vehicle (MIRV) system, marking a major boost to the country's strategic defence capabilities. The missile was tested from Dr APJ Abdul Kalam Island off the Odisha coast on Friday.

The missile was flight-tested with multiple payloads aimed at different targets spread across a large geographical area in the Indian Ocean Region. The MIRV feature ensures that a single missile can deploy multiple warheads at different locations. The missile system was tested on Friday according to the Defence Ministry. "India conducted the successful flight-

trial of an advanced Agni Missile with Multiple Independently Targeted Re-Entry Vehicle (MIRV) system from APJ Abdul Kalam Island, Odisha on May 8," it said.

Agni-5 missile has a range of up to 5,000 km. The Agni 1 to 4 missiles have ranges from 700 km to 3,500 km, and they have already been deployed.

In April 2024, India successfully carried out the maiden flight trial of an endo-atmospheric interceptor missile from a ship off the coast of Odisha in the Bay of Bengal as part of its ambitious ballistic missile defence programme.

The missile was flight-tested with multiple payloads, targeted to different targets spatially distributed over a large geographical area in the Indian Ocean Region, it added.

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Government appoints new CDS, Navy Chief

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Government on Saturday named Lieutenant General (Retd) NS Raja Subramani as the country's next Chief of Defence Staff (CDS), and Vice Admiral Krishna Swaminathan as the new Navy Chief. Orders announcing both new appointments were issued on Saturday.

Widely known as an expert on Pakistan and China, Lt General Subramani retired as Vice Chief of Army Staff and is currently serving as military adviser to the National Security Council Secretariat, will take over as CDS on May 30, replacing General Anil Chauhan.

Vice Admiral Krishna Swaminathan, presently heading the Western Naval Command, will take charge

Lieutenant General NS Raja Subramani

on May 31. Both General Chauhan and Admiral Tripathi are retiring from service.

According to the Ministry of Defence, the Government has appointed Lt General NS Raja Subramani (Retd) as the Chief of Defence Staff, and he

will also function as the Secretary of the Department of Military Affairs.

Lt General Subramani last served as the 47th Vice Chief of Army Staff until July 2025, before retiring and subsequently serving as a military adviser at the National Security Council Secretariat since September.

As Chief of Defence Staff, Subramani's primary task will be to implement the theaterisation model by rolling out integrated military commands. General Chauhan, a former Eastern Army Commander, took charge as the country's senior-most military commander in September 2022, over nine months after the first CDS General Bipin Rawat died in a helicopter crash in Tamil Nadu.

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670 hectares of central ridge declared reserved forest to restore ecology

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

In a landmark move to combat pollution and restore ecological balance in the Capital, the Delhi Government has granted Reserved Forest status to over 670 hectares of the Central Ridge area under the Indian Forest Act, to strengthen environmental protection, biodiversity conservation and pollution control in the national capital. According to an official statement issued on Saturday, the notified area falls under the Western Forest Division and covers parts around Sardar Patel Marg and the President's Estate.

With the present notification of 673.32 hectares of the Central Ridge, the current Government has so far granted Reserved Forest

status to a total of 4754.14 hectares of Ridge areas. The Chief Minister said that other Ridge areas of Delhi would also soon be notified as Reserved Forests under Section 20 and the process is being expedited.

Declaring an area as a reserved forest brings in strict rules prohibiting most activities unless specifically permitted. The move also empowers a Forest Settlement Officer (FSO) to define boundaries.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said the decision marked a major step towards protecting Delhi's ecologically sensitive Ridge areas, often described as the "green lungs" of the city.

"With commitment and determination, our Government has declared nearly 673.32 hectares of the



Central Ridge area as Reserved Forest,"the chief minister said.

The notification would provide stronger statutory protection to the area and

help prevent encroachments, illegal activities and ecological degradation, she added.

The Reserved Forest status has been granted under Section 20 of the Indian

Forest Act, 1927. In the Reserved areas, activities including hunting, grazing, etc, are banned unless specific orders are issued.

"This decision reflects our

commitment towards environmental conservation, expansion of green cover, and securing a safe and balanced future for the coming generations. The process of granting final legal protection to the Ridge areas had remained pending despite their initial notification in 1994 under Section 4 of the Act, she said, adding that the declaration completed an important process that had been pending for more than three decades.

The Central Ridge stretches along both sides of Upper Ridge Road and forms part of the ancient Aravalli hill system, the statement said. The Delhi Ridge is divided into four sections — North Ridge, South-Central Ridge, Central Ridge and Southern Ridge. Together they cover about 7,000 hectares in the

city. The Southern Ridge, spanning 6,200 hectares, is the largest by far, covering about 80 per cent of the total Ridge area. It also encompasses villages such as Asola, Ayanagar, Tughlaqabad, Maidangarhi, and Nebsarai.

The chief minister said the Ridge plays a key role in improving air quality, conserving biodiversity, strengthening groundwater levels and mitigating the impact of climate change and urban pollution.

Around 4,080.82 hectares of the Southern Ridge area had been declared a Reserved Forest on October 24 last year, Gupta said, adding that the Government is expediting the process of notifying the remaining Ridge areas in Delhi as Reserved Forests.

According to the state-

ment, the Government also plans large-scale plantation of native tree species, including neem, peepal, shisham, jamun, tamarind and mango, in suitable areas across the Ridge. The The Chief Minister stated that the declaration of the Central Ridge area as Reserved Forest would now provide stronger statutory protection to the region. This would help prevent encroachments, illegal activities, and ecological degradation. It would also strengthen conservation and scientific management initiatives being undertaken by the Forest Department in Delhi's Ridge areas. Between 1994 and 2025, only 103 hectares of the 7,777 hectares of Ridge land had been officially notified as reserved forest under Section 20 of the Indian Forest Act, 1927.

Urban forests store carbon worth ₹4 lakh/hectare: Study

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

In a city struggling with toxic air and rising temperatures, Delhi's forests have been quietly storing an underground climate treasure. Researchers from the Jawaharlal Nehru University and the University of Delhi have found that urban forests in the national Capitalare absorbing massive amounts of carbon in their trees and soil, with the potential to generate over ₹4 lakh per hectare through carbon credits.

The study said that one hectare of urban forest land inside the JNU campus could store nearly 346.9 tonnes of carbon dioxide equivalent, or around 3,46,900 kilograms. One hectare equals nearly 2.47 acres. Researchers estimated the carbon credit value of this storage at nearly \$4,846, or more than ₹4 lakh per hectare.

According to the study, the biggest carbon storage was happening underground rather than in trees. Researchers said soil organic carbon accounted for more than 43 per cent of the total carbon stored in the ecosystem. The soil alone stored nearly 149.73 tonnes, or around 1,49,730 kilograms, of carbon dioxide equivalent per hectare, with an estimated carbon credit value of nearly \$2,096 or around ₹1.74 lakh per hectare.

Among tree species, neem (Azadirachta indica) and babool (Acacia nilotica) emerged as the strongest carbon absorbers in the forest ecosystem studied by researchers.

The study found neem trees stored 55.10 tonnes, or around 55,100 kilograms, of carbon dioxide equivalent per hectare, with an estimated carbon credit value of over \$771, or more than ₹64,000. Babool trees stored



54.43 tonnes, or around 54,430 kilograms, of carbon dioxide equivalent per hectare, valued at around \$762, or over ₹63,000.

Researchers also found that litter on the forest floor, shrubs, herbs and underground microbial activity contributed significantly to carbon storage, showing that entire forest ecosystems, and not just large trees, help absorb greenhouse gases.

The researchers said urban forests in Delhi could become

critical natural buffers against rising emissions and worsening climate conditions in the city if protected and expanded properly.

The study noted that native species such as neem and babool are especially important in semi-arid urban conditions because of their high carbon storage potential and ability to survive harsh climatic conditions.

Researchers also found that forests with greater biodiversity and healthier soil

stored more carbon overall.

The findings come amid the Delhi Government's push to monetise pollution reduction through a Carbon Credit Monetisation Framework approved by the Cabinet in January this year.

Under the framework, pollution reduction achieved through electric buses, plantation drives, solar energy projects and waste management initiatives will be scientifically measured and converted into carbon credits that can be sold in national and international markets.

A carbon credit is essentially a tradable certificate representing one tonne of carbon dioxide removed from the atmosphere or prevented from being released. Governments and companies buy these credits to balance out their emissions.

According to the Chief Minister's Office, the Environment Department will appoint a specialised

agency through a tender process to identify projects eligible for carbon credits and register them under international standards.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta had said the framework would help Delhi strengthen climate action efforts while also generating additional revenue for development works.

For the study, researchers examined forest patches spread across the 1,019-acre JNU campus (nearly 412 hectares). They created five separate study plots and used stratified random sampling methods to record tree species, trunk diameter, tree height and biomass.

Researchers also collected soil samples up to a depth of 30 centimetres and analysed them in laboratories to measure organic carbon, nitrogen and microbial activity. The study recorded 11 dominant tree species with an overall density of 826 trees per hectare.

Cooling zone near Jama Masjid set up under heat-wave action plan

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Even as the Rekha Gupta Government is adopting various measures to provide relief to the citizens from severe heat in the national capital, a cooling zone near the Jama Masjid has been set up under its "Heat-wave Action Plan".

The tent-like structure has been installed to provide relief and comfort to the people while they venture out amid rising temperatures. The facility allows around 70 to 80 people to sit and rest at a time, offering much-needed respite to commuters, tourists, rickshaw

pullers, labourers, senior citizens and passersby affected by the scorching heat.

The cooling zones or camps, managed with the support of the Delhi Disaster Management Authority and Civil Defence volunteers, are helping people cope with the intense summer conditions.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said continuous access to chilled drinking water has been arranged through water coolers at the site. In addition, ORS-mixed water is also being provided to help people stay hydrated and avoid heat-stroke and dehydration.

The chief minister said



her Government's objective is not only to put arrangements in place but also deliver tangible relief directly to the people. She noted that markets, religious

places, and tourist hubs witness heavy footfall during the summer months, making densely populated areas like Old Delhi particularly vulnerable during

extreme heat conditions.

Keeping this in mind, the cooling zone has been created as a permanent relief facility, separate from the mobile heat relief vehicles already operating in the city.

In the statement, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said that officials have been instructed to identify the other high-footfall areas across the Capitalwhere similar facilities can be established.

The Government's objective is not merely to put arrangements in place, but to deliver tangible relief directly to the people, she said.

She further said the Delhi Government is working on a

multi-layered strategy to tackle the heatwave situation. This includes relief measures across districts, improved drinking water availability, public awareness campaigns and special arrangements in sensitive areas. With temperatures expected to rise further in the coming days, all concerned departments have been directed to remain on alert.

The Chief Minister also appealed to residents to take necessary precautions during peak afternoon hours, drink sufficient water and make use of the relief facilities being provided by the Government wherever required.

Three held for black-marketing IPL tickets; 87 passes, ₹25,000 seized

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi



tip-off about the illegal sale of IPL tickets. "The accused were allegedly posing as authorised representatives of the Delhi and District Cricket Association (DDCA) and selling tickets at inflated prices to unsuspecting buyers," a police officer said.

He said 54 IPL tickets, including 33 complimentary passes marked "not for sale," and ₹25,000 in cash were recovered from their possession.

The accused told police they sold complimentary passes for nearly ₹20,000 each and regular tickets for almost double their printed price, depending on the match's popularity and the buyers' profile, police said.

Investigators said the accused were part of a black-market network for IPL tickets across different cities where matches were held.

"They allegedly travelled by air to various venues and procured tickets and

passes through different sources," the officer said.

Police also suspect that premium tickets were supplied to people involved in online betting syndicates operating inside stadiums, in addition to other criminal elements.

The officer said an FIR filed, three accused arrested and are on police remand, and efforts are underway to identify other members. Police said the accused were previously involved in multiple criminal cases registered in Delhi, Punjab and Haryana, including cheating, gambling and ticket black marketing.

Meanwhile, the secretary of the Board of Control for Cricket in India, Devajit Saikia, on Thursday said the decision to shift the IPL 2026 final from Bengaluru to Ahmedabad was taken after the Karnataka State Cricket Association allegedly sought complimentary tickets far beyond the

23 officers reshuffled; Navin Kumar ACS GAD, Sandeep Kumar PWD secy

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

In a major administrative reshuffle involving 23 senior IAS and DANICS officers, the Delhi Government has posted Navin Kumar Choudhary as Additional Chief Secretary of the General Administration Department.

A services department order said the 1997-batch Arunachal Pradesh-Goa-Mizoram and Union Territories (AGMUT) cadre IAS officer Sandeep Kumar will be the principal secretary of Public Works Department (PWD), earlier headed by Choudhary.

Vikas Anand (2002 IAS), secretary to the chief minis-



ter, will also serve as Director of the Union Territory Civil Services (UTCS), replacing Bipul Pathak, besides holding the post of Secretary, Information and Publicity department.

The reshuffle involved 12 IAS and 11 DANICS (Delhi Andaman & Nicobar Lakshadweep Daman and Diu and Dadra and Nagar Haveli Civil Services) officers.

DANICS officer Prashant Kumar, 2010 batch, holding the charge of Additional Secretary in the Public Grievances Commission under the chief minister's Office, will also hold additional charge of Director of the Directorate of Information and Publicity (DIP), said the order.

In other important changes, Dilraj Kaur (2000 IAS), awaiting posting, has been appoint-

ed Managing Director of the Delhi Scheduled Castes Finance and Development Corporation with additional charge of the Delhi Cooperative Housing Finance Corporation.

Nandini Paliwal (2003 IAS) was appointed Secretary (Vigilance) and was also given additional charge of Secretary (Services) and Chairperson of the Delhi Subordinate Services Selection Board (DSSSB).

Yashpal Garg (2008) was posted as Secretary (Planning) with additional charge of Secretary (Land and Building) and Development Commissioner.

G Sudhakar (2012 IAS), district magistrate of Central

Delhi, has been posted as director of the Women and Child Development department with additional charge of managing director of the State Urban Livelihoods Mission.

Kishore Kshirasagar Lakshman (2010 IAS) was appointed District Magistrate (Old Delhi), and Yash Chaudhary was posted as Special Secretary (Health).

Cheemala Siva Gopal Reddy (2020 IAS) was appointed Special Secretary to the Lieutenant Governor, while Rajeev Singh was made Member of the Delhi Urban Shelter Improvement Board with additional charge of Special Secretary (Land and Building).



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The national Capitalis on high alert following intelligence inputs indicating a possible terror threat. This prompted the Delhi Police and other security agencies to intensify vigil across several sensitive locations.

A source said security has been increased at the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) headquarters on Deen Dayal Upadhyaya (DDU) Marg and nearby Government establishments, with additional deployment of armed personnel, barricading and intensified vehicle checks.

According to sources, agencies have received alerts regarding possible attempts to target prominent offices and crowded areas in central Delhi using suicide attacks, vehicle-borne improvised explosive devices (IEDs), shootings and coordinated strikes.

Sources said anti-sabotage checks are being carried out at important Government buildings, political offices, markets, transport hubs and other crowded places across the city. Bomb disposal squads, sniffer dog units and quick reaction teams, including the Delhi Fire Service, have also

been asked to stay alert.

"Police have been directed to maintain strict vigil on suspicious movements, unattended objects and vehicles parked in sensitive zones," said the source.

Security arrangements have also been strengthened at settlements and areas considered vulnerable from a law-and-order perspective; local police are conducting random checking drives and verification exercises.

The source said all district units have been instructed to remain alert and maintain close coordination with intelligence agencies and central paramilitary forces. Senior officers are continuously monitoring the situation and reviewing security arrangements across the city, said the source.

Special Cell, the anti-terrorist unit of Delhi Police, has unmasked an alleged terror conspiracy orchestrated by Pakistan's Inter-Services Intelligence (ISI) through a module linked to Pakistan-based gangster and ISI proxy Shahzad Bhatti. The module reportedly planned coordinated attacks on a historic temple in Delhi, a crowded dhaba on the Delhi-Sonapat highway and a military camp in Hisar, Haryana.

52 in Yamuna Bazar floodplains get eviction notices over safety risk

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Eviction notices have been issued to 52 "illegal" occupants residing in unsafe structures within the flood-control boundary wall along Yamuna Bazar ghats, with authorities saying that encroachment on the floodplains poses a serious threat to life, property and public safety.

In a post on X on Saturday, the district magistrate (Old Delhi) said flooding in 2023 and 2025 had prompted

large-scale relief operations in the area, putting heavy strain on public resources.

"Illegal occupation in Yamuna flood plains (O-Zone) poses a serious threat to life, property and public safety. Repeated flooding in 2023 and 2025 led to large-scale relief operations, putting heavy strain on public resources," the post said.

It further said preventive action is essential to safeguard human lives and restore the Yamuna floodplains.

The remarks came days



after the DDMA issued eviction notices to around 300 "illegal" households in Yamuna Bazar area on May 7, directing them to vacate the encroached floodplain land within 15 days.

According to the notice, an

illegal residential cluster comprising around 310 dwellings exists within the flood-control wall along the Yamuna banks in the O-Zone, a protected no-construction floodplain owned by the Delhi Development Authority (DDA).

"The same is being inundated during Yamuna floods every year thereby posing a serious threat to the loss of human life, cattle and property," the notice stated.

Invoking powers under Section 34 of the Disaster Management Act, 2005, the

DDMA directed residents occupying the encroached area to remove their belongings and vacate the premises voluntarily within 15 days of issuance of the notice.

It warned that failure to comply would lead to demolition action without further notice. The action came a week after Lt Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu chaired a review meeting with DDA officials on the progress of rejuvenation works in the Yamuna Bazar area following his visit there.

IN FOCUS



Tigress Rani, front left, with her cubs, inside their enclosure on the eve of International Women's Day at the Nahargarh Biological Park near Jaipur, Rajasthan on Saturday

PTI

Constitution, not Parliament, supreme in India: Ex-CJI Gavai

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

New Delhi

A constitutional democracy is not organised around a single centre of power, former chief justice of India BR Gavai said on Saturday, while emphasising that Parliament is not supreme in the country but the Constitution is. Speaking at the 19th Sujata Jayawardena Memorial Oration organised by the University of Colombo, Justice Gavai said clashes between Parliament and the judiciary have led to the evolution of constitutional safeguards and doctrines to manage such conflicts.

The former judge said it is not Parliament, nor the executive, nor even the judiciary that is supreme, but it is the Constitution. All three derive their authority from it, and all three are bound by it, he asserted.

"A constitutional democracy is not organised around a single centre of power. It is not a system in which one institution exercises unchecked authority. Rather, it is a carefully-calibrated arrangement in which power is distributed, structured and limited. In



the Indian constitutional scheme, Parliament is not supreme in any absolute sense. Nor is any other organ. The only supremacy that the Constitution recognises is its own. All institutions derive their authority from it and all are bound by its limits," Justice Gavai said. Referring to BR Ambedkar's speech in the constituent assembly, Gavai said each organ of State has its domain. Each is supreme within that domain, but only to extent permitted by Constitution, he pointed out.

The former CJI said the relationship between Parliament and the judiciary is not always adversarial. "At times, it is collaborative, where judicial innovation identifies constitutional gaps, and Parliament responds by institutionalising those principles within a democratic framework.

Vadodara gears up for PM Modi roadshow; preparations reviewed

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

Vadodara

Prime Minister Narendra Modi is scheduled to visit Vadodara on May 11 for the inauguration of a hostel project at Sardar Dham near Waghodia Chowkdi, with the city administration intensifying preparations for a large-scale roadshow planned later in the evening.

Ahead of the visit, Gujarat Minister of State for Home Harsh Sanghavi conducted a late-night review of arrangements in Vadodara. He held meetings with senior officials, including the police commissioner, municipal commissioner, district collector, range IG, local legislators and party office-bearers at the old airport premises before inspecting the proposed roadshow route.



According to officials, the roadshow is expected to begin from Gada Circle and conclude at Harni Airport, covering a key stretch of the city. Extensive preparations, including barricading, lighting and security deployment, have been underway for the past week.

Authorities estimate that

nearly 40,000 people may attend the event. Local representatives and several social, educational, cultural, business and religious organisations have reportedly been mobilised to ensure public participation. Arrangements are also being made to bring supporters from nearby districts

through bus services. To manage the crowd, around 16 viewing stages are expected to be installed along both sides of the route. Officials said the roadshow is likely to start around 7 pm and conclude within approximately 30 minutes.

The administration is also planning decorative lighting along the route to create a festive atmosphere. Special focus is being placed on crowd comfort due to the prevailing heat, with medical teams, ambulances, drinking water, ORS and temporary toilet facilities being arranged for attendees.

Security agencies, including SPG personnel, have also inspected the route and held coordination meetings with various departments to ensure smooth conduct of the VVIP movement.

EU-India partnership limitless, ambitious and progressive: Envoy

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

New Delhi

The European Union-India partnership is "limitless, ambitious and progressive" and both sides have elevated the relationship to a "totally new level" in both qualitative and strategic terms, EU Ambassador Herve Delphin has said.

In an address at an event, the envoy also noted that Prime Minister Narendra Modi's "not an era of war" message "deeply resonates" with Europe's values and identity, and called the EU "fundamentally a peace project".

Characterising the EU-India summit held three and a half months ago as a milestone, Delphin said the confluence of symbolism, substance and strategic significance resulted in "momentous outcomes".

"We have placed our relationship to a totally new level, in qualitative and strategic terms. The EU-India partnership is limitless, ambitious and progressive," he said.

"These achievements would not have been possible without the political conviction and trust shared by our leaders," the envoy said at the Europe Day celebrations on Friday night.



Delphin cited the unveiling of a joint strategic agenda for the next five years, the conclusion of negotiations for an ambitious free trade agreement, the signing of a security and defence partnership pact and the firming up of a comprehensive framework on mobility as major take-aways from the summit.

"Fundamentally, we are global forces for good. We are both recognised as trusted, reliable partners working for global stability and prosperity, promoting global cooperation and solutions," he said.

"That India and the EU and its member States are deepening their ties like never before is truly a reason for celebration this year. This is the Europe-India moment," Delphin said in the presence of Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman and a sizeable number of

diplomats, academicians and foreign policy experts. The envoy characterised the presence of European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen and European Council President Antonio Costa as the Chief Guests at India's Republic Day parade and the EU-India summit as a "moment where symbolism, substance and strategic significance came together, resulting in momentous outcomes".

The free trade agreement between the two sides has been billed as the "mother of all" trade deals.

"We are already India's leading trading partner. With the FTA in place, we expect our two-way trade to double in value in the next few years," Delphin said.

The envoy also cited a report titled the "EU business economic footprint in India"

released this week that analysed various dimensions of the two-way economic engagement.

"About 6000 EU companies, generating the creation of close to six million jobs, exporting close to 25 billion euros (worth of goods) from India to the world (6 per cent of India's total exports)," he said.

The EU, as a bloc, is India's largest trading partner in goods. For the financial year 2024-25, India's total trade in goods with the EU was worth about \$136 billion, with exports around \$76 billion and imports at \$60 billion.

In his remarks, Delphin also mentioned what he described as Russia's "war of aggression" against Ukraine.

"Wars cause immense human suffering, massive economic losses. Ultimately, aggressors end up paying the higher price. Russia is not winning but losing the war of aggression it deliberately launched," he said.

"We will continue to stand with Ukraine and in support of a just and lasting peace. This message of (PM Modi) - 'not an era of war' - deeply resonates with Europe's values and identity," he said.

"The EU is fundamentally a peace project, turning the back on centuries of continental wars," Delphin added.

Hantavirus containable, not highly contagious: Soumya Swaminathan



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

New Delhi

Former WHO chief scientist Soumya Swaminathan has said the ongoing Hantavirus outbreak linked to a cruise ship appears "containable" as the virus requires prolonged close contact for transmission, unlike highly contagious ones like COVID-19, measles or influenza.

Swaminathan said the long incubation period of the virus — estimated at six to eight weeks — explains why the first case on the cruise ship surfaced nearly a month after the vessel sailed in early April. "The incubation period of this virus is quite long, and this is why it took almost a month for the first person on the ship to get it," she said.

Believing that the ship sailed on April 2-3 and the first lady got sick at the end of April, she said, the incubation period is six to eight weeks and therefore, to be on the safe side, "these people will have to be isolated till that time."

The former World Health Organisation chief scientist said the safest strategy

would be to isolate everyone who was on the ship or had close contact with infected individuals for the entire incubation window, though some countries may choose to isolate only symptomatic people.

"Some countries might say that you only isolate if you have symptoms, but a lot of countries are basically asking people to self-isolate till the incubation period is over," she said.

She added that anyone developing symptoms during the isolation period should be immediately tested for Hantavirus infection and said strict adherence to isolation measures could effectively halt further spread. "Essentially, if you do that till the incubation period is over, then the chances of spread are basically nil," she said.

Explaining the transmission pattern, Swaminathan said the current strain is likely the only known Hantavirus capable of spreading from human to human and that transmission so far has been linked to prolonged close physical contact.

Bodies of two slain Bangladeshi smugglers handed over to relatives

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

Agartala

Bodies of two suspected Bangladeshi smugglers who were shot dead by Border Security Force in Tripura's Sepahijala district were handed over to their relatives through Kamalasagar BOP in the presence of BSF and BGB officials, police said on Saturday. During routine patrolling, BSF jawans spotted a group of 15

Bangladeshi persons smuggling fishlingers at Pathariadwar, an Indian village, on Friday night.

"On being challenged, the smugglers started pelting stones at BSF troops and in self-defence, the jawans opened fire from PAG (Pump Action Guns) guns, resulting in two suspected persons falling on the ground," said Ujjal Choudhury, Officer in Charge (OC) of Madhupur police station.

WEST BENGAL TURNS SAFFRON

In his brief address after taking the oath, Adhikari thanked Prime Minister Modi and the party high command for their support. "This is not just a victory for the BJP but for the people of Bengal who voted for change," he said. "We will work with complete dedication to fulfil the aspirations of *Ma, Mati, and Manush*."

He announced that the new Government would prioritise industrial revival, law and order, and welfare schemes for farmers and women. The maiden cabinet reflects a blend of veteran leaders and rising stars drawn from diverse regions and social sections of the state, signalling the BJP's intent to build a broad-based team. Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari, who secured victories in both Bhabanipur and Nandigram, is the central figure. A seasoned politician with deep roots in East Midnapore, he is expected to provide decisive leadership for the people of West Bengal. Dilip Ghosh, former state unit president of the BJP and a prominent grassroots organiser, brings decades of party-building experience. Known for his strong connection with the party's ideological base and rural Bengal, Ghosh was a key architect of the BJP's expansion in the State. Agnimitra Paul, a senior leader of the BJP's women's wing and a former popular Bengali actress, adds a dynamic presence focused on women's empowerment and cultural outreach. Her inclusion underscores the party's emphasis on engaging urban and youth voters. Ashok Kirtania, an influential OBC voice from the northern districts, strengthens the representation of backward classes and strengthens the government's outreach in the Dooars and Terai regions. Kshudiram Tudu, hailing from the tribal heartland of Jangalmahal, symbolises the BJP's growing engagement with Scheduled Tribe communities and issues concerning forest dwellers and rural development.

Nisith Pramanik, the young and energetic leader from Cooch Behar who previously served as a Union Minister of State, injects administrative experience and ensures seamless coordination between the State and Central Governments. The compact six-member cabinet is seen as a strategic starting point, allowing the new government to move swiftly on key priorities while leaving space for future expansion. The Assembly is expected to witness the Government proving its majority within the next 10 days.

For Bengal, the day marks not just a change of guard but the beginning of a new political era. Whether the BJP can translate its electoral

triumph into stable and inclusive governance remains the central question as Suwendu Adhikari begins his innings as Chief Minister.

Political observers note that the compact initial cabinet of six members is a deliberate move by the BJP to ensure tight control in the early days while leaving room for expansion. The Government is expected to prove its majority on the floor of the Assembly within the next 10 days.

Yogi likely to expand Cabinet today

The proposed expansion is learnt to have been planned with an eye on the 2027 Uttar Pradesh assembly polls, with the BJP focusing on caste and regional representation as part of a wider social-balancing strategy. Among the likely entrants is Bhupendra Chaudhary, a Jat OBC leader from Moradabad and former Uttar Pradesh BJP chief who is currently a member of the legislative council (MLC).

Another key name is Manoj Pandey, a Brahmin leader and MLA from Unchahar in Raebareilly district who rebelled against the Samajwadi Party before moving closer to the BJP camp.

Pooja Lal, an OBC leader from the Pal community and MLA from Chayal in Kaushambi, is also among the probable inductees. She, too, is a rebel from the Samajwadi Party.

The sources further said Ashok Kataria, a Gurjar OBC leader and MLC from Bijnor, is likely to find a place in the expanded council of ministers. Two leaders from the Pasi community are also expected to be accommodated. These include Krishna Paswan, an SC leader and MLA from Khaga in Fatehpur, and Suresh Pasi, a Pasi community leader and MLA from Jagdishpur in Amethi. The development comes at a politically crucial time for the ruling BJP, which is looking to consolidate its social coalition after the setbacks it faced in Uttar Pradesh during the 2024 Lok Sabha elections.

Yogi Adityanath first became chief minister of Uttar Pradesh in 2017 after the BJP swept the assembly elections, defeating the SP-Congress alliance. The BJP returned to power again in 2022 under his leadership, defeating the Samajwadi Party-led opposition and making history by becoming the first party in nearly four decades to retain power in Uttar Pradesh consecutively.

In the 403-member Uttar Pradesh assembly, the BJP currently has 255 MLAs, while its allies, including the Apna Dal (Sonelal) and NISHAD Party, Suheldeo Bharatiya Samaj Party (SBSP) take the National Democratic Alliance tally comfortably past the majority mark.

FROM PAGE - 1

Government appoints New CDS, Navy Chief

In his illustrious career spanning over 40 years, Lt General Subramani served across a wide spectrum of conflict and terrain profiles and held a host of Command, Staff and Instructional appointments. He served as the Vice Chief of the Army Staff from July 1, 2024, to July 31, 2025, and was General Officer Commanding-in-Chief of the Central Command from March 2023 till June 2024. The officer is a graduate of the National Defence Academy and the Indian Military Academy. He was commissioned into the eighth battalion of the Garhwal Rifles on December 14, 1985.

Lt General Subramani is an alumnus of the Joint Services Command and Staff College, Bracknell (UK), and the National Defence College, New Delhi. He holds a Master of Arts degree from King's College, London, and an MPhil in Defence Studies from Madras University. He commanded the 16 Garhwal Rifles in counter-insurgency operations in Assam as part of Operation Rhino, the 168 Infantry Brigade in Jammu and Kashmir, and the 17 Mountain Division in the Central Sector during a challenging operational environment.

He is an alumnus of the National Defence Academy, Khadakvasla; the Joint Services Command and Staff College, Shrivenham, United Kingdom; the College of Naval Warfare, Karanja; and the US Naval War College, Newport.

A recipient of the Param Vishisht Seva Medal (PVSM), Ati Vishisht Seva Medal (AVSM) and Vishisht Seva Medal (VSM), the Admiral has held several key operational, staff and training appointments in his naval career, including the command of missile vessels INS Vidyut and Vinash, the missile corvette INS Kulish, the guided missile destroyer INS Mysore and the aircraft carrier INS Vikramaditya.

Following his promotion to the rank of Vice Admiral, the Flag Officer served as Chief of Staff of the Western Naval Command, Controller of Personnel Services, and Chief of Personnel at Naval Headquarters. Prior to his current assignment, he served as Vice Chief of the Naval Staff. Vice Admiral Swaminathan's educational qualifications include a BSc degree from Jawaharlal Nehru University, New Delhi; an MSc in Telecommunications from Cochin University of Science and Technology; and an MA in Defence Studies from King's College, London. He also holds an MPhil in Strategic Studies and a PhD in International Studies, both from Mumbai University.

India tests advanced Agni missile from Odisha...

The Government said telemetry and tracking operations were carried out through multiple ground-based and ship-based stations, which monitored the missile's trajectory from launch until the impact of all payloads. "Flight data confirmed that all mission objectives were met during the trial," the Government said.

The successful test demonstrated India's capability to engage multiple strategic targets using a single missile system through MIRV technology, which allows one missile to carry and deliver several warheads to separate targets. The missile has been developed by laboratories under the Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO) with support from industries across the country. The trial was witnessed by senior scientists of DRDO and the Indian Army personnel. Defence Minister Rajnath Singh congratulated DRDO, the Indian Army and industry partners for the successful test. Singh said the achievement would add "an incredible capability" to India's defence preparedness amid evolving security challenges and growing threat perceptions.

PM bows, thanks voters

After entering the Brigade Parade Grounds, Modi, accompanied by Adhikari and state BJP president Samik Bhattacharya, took a ride in an open-air jeep and waved at the thousands of BJP workers and supporters who were present at the venue. The entire Brigade Parade Grounds was decked in saffron colours. A large number of artists were performing to the tune of traditional drums.

After taking a ride in the vehicle, PM Modi went to the stage and met all the dignitaries, including Union Home Minister Amit Shah, Defence Minister Rajnath Singh, Union Ministers, Chief Ministers of BJP-ruled States and other leaders. Modi then greeted Makhanlal Sarkar, one of the most senior workers of the BJP in the state, presented him with a shawl and took his blessings.

Governor invites Vijay to form Govt

He added that he continued in DMK-led Secular Progressive Alliance. His party's stance was already conveyed to DMK chief MK Stalin, who had agreed to the unanimous decision of the

VCK and the Left parties, he said. Shortly after VCK's decision to back Vijay, another DMK ally, the IUML also extended support to TVK. Both IUML and VCK have two MLAs each.

With the two small parties' support, the numbers in favour of TVK rose to 120, including 5 from the Congress, just two more than the simple majority mark of 118 in the 234-member Tamil Nadu Assembly. Both CPI and CPI (M) won two seats each respectively, while the TVK on its own secured 108 seats in the Assembly elections held on April 23. The results were declared on May 4. Vijay, who has won from two segments, has to resign from one of them, which brings down the party's strength to 107.

ED arrests Punjab minister Sanjeev Arora...

Arora (62) was taken into custody under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA) following early morning raids at his official residence in Chandigarh, officials said. They claimed that the minister was "non-cooperative" during the investigation. He will be brought to Delhi, where the case is registered, and the agency will seek his remand for custodial interrogation, the officials said. In less than a year after being sworn in as a minister, Arora has emerged as a key member of the AAP Government in Punjab, holding several important portfolios — industries and commerce, investment promotion, power and local Government.

Before the arrest, the ED conducted searches at five locations across northern India earlier in the day as part of the operation. These included two premises in Delhi and a company named Hampton Sky Realty Ltd in Udyog Vihar, Gurugram.

The inputs for the latest case emerged from a FEMA search that the ED had undertaken against Arora and some others on April 27. The latest probe (under the PMLA) pertains to "fake" GST purchases of mobile phones worth more than Rs 100 crore and subsequent exports to "round trip" alleged illegitimate funds from Dubai to India, according to the ED.

Punjab Chief Minister Mann criticised the ED action during a press conference in Sangrur. "The end of this unethical alliance of ED-BJP will begin from Punjab," he said. In a post on X, Kejriwal likened the prime minister to Aurangzeb and alleged that, like the Mughal emperor, "Modiji has dishonestly occupied various parts of the country and has now reached Punjab".

Congress demands Parliament talk on China’s support to Pak

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Congress on Saturday demanded a discussion in Parliament on claims made by China that it provided on-site technical support to Pakistan during Operation Sindoor last year.

Congress general secretary (communications) Jairam Ramesh posed questions to the Narendra Modi Government, asking why investment and trade curbs on China are being loosened and why the Government is seeking to deepen India's industrial dependency on China.

“As the Modi Government follows a 4C policy - Continuing Calibrated Capitulation to China - comes confirmation of China's pivotal role in Pakistan's response to Operation Sindoor,” he said in a post on X. Ramesh said engineers from Aviation Industry Corporation of China's Chengdu Aircraft Design and Research Institute, a key developer of China's



Jairam Ramesh

advanced fighter aircraft and unmanned aerial vehicle design, confirmed they provided technical support to the Pakistani Air Force.

“This has not been a secret. It was Deputy Chief of Army Staff Lt General Rahul Singh who had first publicly revealed details of China's pivotal real-time role on July 4, 2025. This raises the 4-Whys.

“Why did our Prime Minister - he of the 5.6-inch chest and the tear-stricken lal aankh - give a clean chit to China on June 19, 2020, and

completely undercut our negotiating position?” he asked.

The Congress leader also asked why the Modi Government agreed to the loss of our traditional patrolling and herding rights in many places in Ladakh.

“Why has the Modi Government failed to even whimper against such an openly hostile action from the Chinese Government during Operation Sindoor?

“Why are investment and trade curbs on China being loosened, and why is the

Government seeking to deepen our industrial dependency on China with imports reaching record levels?

“These issues must be discussed in Parliament,” Ramesh said in his post.

The questions by Congress came after China, for the first time, confirmed that it provided on-site technical support to Pakistan during the four-day conflict with India last year.

China's state broadcaster CCTV on Thursday aired an interview with Zhang Heng, an engineer from the Aviation Industry Corporation of China's (AVIC) Chengdu Aircraft Design and Research Institute, a key developer of China's advanced fighter aircraft and unmanned aerial vehicle design.

Zhang had provided technical support to Pakistan during the four-day war last May, Hong Kong-based South China Morning Post reported, quoting CCTV.

Pakistan's air force operates a fleet of Chinese-made J-10CE jets, produced by an AVIC subsidiary.

Union Minister Sanjay Kumar’s son booked under POCSO

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Hyderabad

A case under the POCSO Act was registered against Union Minister Bandi Sanjay Kumar's son here following allegations of sexual harassment of a minor girl, a charge denied by the accused, who alleged extortion and criminal intimidation by the teen and her parents.

According to the 17-year-old girl's mother, Sanjay Kumar's son Bhageerath, who



was in a relationship with her daughter, sexually harassed her.

The alleged relationship began about seven to eight months ago, police said.

They are yet to examine

the girl, who is a student.

Meanwhile, Bhageerath complained to the police in Karimnagar that the girl who got acquainted to him, invited him to her family functions and group gatherings.

An FIR was registered based on the complaint.

Bhageerath said in the complaint that, believing the girl's family to be trustworthy, he accompanied them and visited some holy places, as part of a friend's group.

Subsequently, the girl and her parents intimidated him into marrying her, but he rejected the proposal, following which the girl's parents demanded money and also threatened him with false complaints if he failed to pay the amount.

Out of fear, he paid Rs 50,000 to the girl's father, but they demanded Rs five crore. If he failed to comply, the girl's mother would commit suicide, Bhageerath alleged in his complaint.

BJP hits back at Kejriwal over Aurangzeb remark on PM Modi

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The BJP hit back at Arvind Kejriwal on Saturday for likening Prime Minister Narendra Modi to Mughal emperor Aurangzeb over ED raids against Punjab minister Sanjeev Arora, saying the AAP supremo and his party are rattled as they know that “their days are numbered in Punjab”.

The remarks came after Kejriwal slammed the ED action against Arora in a post on X and addressed a press conference here on Saturday.

In the post, the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) national convenor likened the prime minister to Aurangzeb and wrote that like the Mughal emperor, “Modiji has dishonestly occupied various parts of the country and has now reached Punjab”.

At the press conference, Kejriwal slammed Modi over the Enforcement Directorate's (ED) raids



against Arora on Saturday, alleging misuse of the federal agency to scare AAP leaders into joining the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP).

Hitting back at him, BJP spokesperson RP Singh said corruption allegations against AAP leaders are not baseless and claimed that it is Kejriwal, and not Modi, who is carrying out “Aurangzeb-like” actions in Punjab.

“While the Punjab Police is not taking action against killings, the drug mafia or the sand mafia in the State, it is being used to target political opponents,” Singh said.

He alleged that the Punjab Police was sent to arrest a Rajya Sabha MP who has left the AAP in a “fake case”.

“In reality, it is Kejriwal who is behaving like Aurangzeb in Punjab. Punjab today is troubled by these Aurangzeb-like actions of his,” Singh alleged.

He claimed that notices were issued through the Pollution Control Board against a factory linked to another Rajya Sabha MP who has left the AAP and that demolition action was initiated against a building belonging to a publishing house.

Kashmiri Pandits protest in Jammu; seek rehabilitation policy, fresh job package

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jammu

Displaced Kashmiri Pandits on Saturday staged a protest demonstration in Jammu, demanding the formulation and implementation of a comprehensive rehabilitation policy for the community in Kashmir Valley and the announcement of a fresh employment package for 15,000 educated displaced youth under the prime minister's special package.

Carrying placards and raising slogans in support of their demands, including return and rehabilitation, employment opportunities and proper political representation, the protesters assembled outside the Press Club here under the banner of Youth All India Kashmiri Samaj (YAICS).

The protest was led by YAICS president RK Bhat, who said the community had once again taken to the streets to press for its long-pending



Members of the Youth All India Kashmiri Samaj (YAICS) raise slogans during a protest over various demands for displaced Kashmiri Pandits in Jammu PTI

demands. Bhat appealed to the Narendra Modi-led Government to facilitate the return of Kashmiri Pandits to their “motherland” after nearly 37 years of displacement.

“We believe Prime Minister Narendra Modi's vision must ensure justice and rightful rehabilitation for Kashmiri Pandits. We appeal to the prime minister to formulate a comprehensive return and rehabilitation package in the

Valley for the entire community,” he told reporters.

He said the community had faith in the prime minister, Lieutenant Governor Manoj Sinha and the Union Territory administration.

“The Kashmiri Pandit community has hit the streets from today. This is the same organisation that, in 2010, motivated Kashmiri Pandit youth to return to the Kashmir Valley. Even today, that movement continues in

another form,” Bhat said.

He urged the Government to place a concrete rehabilitation proposal before the community, saying it should include employment opportunities for youth, provisions for overage aspirants and relief holders, besides restoration of rights and livelihoods lost during displacement.

Calling for a dignified and collective return of displaced families, he said strong resolutions should be passed reflecting the intention to rehabilitate Kashmiri Pandits in the Valley.

Bhat said around 15,000 Kashmiri Pandit youth were ready to return to the Valley if proper compensation, infrastructure and employment support were ensured.

He also demanded the implementation of court rulings delivered in favour of displaced Pandits in different cases and sought employment for affected families willing to return.

Kharge, Rahul to take decision on Kerala CM

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Congress chief Mallikarjun Kharge and Rahul Gandhi will take the final decision on the new Kerala chief minister, and the name will be announced very soon, AICC general secretary in-charge of the State Deepa Dasmunshi said on Saturday.

She was addressing the media after the Congress' top brass held an over three-hour meeting to discuss Government formation in Kerala.

The meeting was convened by Kharge at his residence, where Rahul Gandhi, Dasmunshi, General Secretary, Organisation, KC Venugopal, and senior Kerala leaders Ramesh Chennithala and VD Satheesan were present, besides Kerala Congress unit chief Sunny Joseph and senior observers, Ajay Maken and Mukul Wasnik.

“Very soon, in due time, we will get our final decision by our high command,” Dasmunshi said on who would be the chief minister in Kerala.

“Congress chief Mallikarjun Kharge and

Rahul Gandhi will take the final decision,” she said when asked as to “who in the high command will take the call”.

“All Congress MLAs have signed a one-line resolution authorising the high command to make the final decision,” she said.

Referring to protests in Kerala in the last two days over the issue of the chief ministerial candidate, she said some unruly incidents have happened, and they are not part of the Congress culture.

“People have given us a landslide majority, and those unruly incidents are not our Congress culture. We are urging all our workers to stop this kind of activity,” she told reporters.

When pressed further about the announcement of the chief minister's name, she replied, “We will have a final decision very soon.”

“23rd May is the last day. I think in due time, we will get the final decision by our high command, and we are waiting for that. In due time, the due course of action will be taken. The final decision has to be taken by the high command,” she said.



Nation Focus



SUBRATA GUPTA APPOINTED WEST BENGAL CM'S ADVISOR

Retired IAS officer Subrata Gupta was on Saturday appointed the adviser to West Bengal Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari, according to a notification.

Gupta, an officer of the 1990 batch, was engaged by the Election Commission of India (India) as the Special Roll Observer for the SIR exercise, held prior to the recently concluded assembly elections. “Gupta's vast experience is expected to help the new administration in policy coordination and governance-related matters,” an official said. The new BJP Government also appointed IAS officer Shantanu Bala as the chief minister's private secretary, according to another notification.



INDIA TO SOLIDIFY TIES WITH AFRICA AT CRUCIAL SUMMIT

India is set to unveil an ambitious roadmap to further solidify its ties with the African continent at a crucial summit on May 31 that will primarily focus on ramping up cooperation in an array of sectors in the face of increasing geopolitical upheavals.

Top leaders of a sizeable number of African nations are expected to attend the fourth India Africa Forum Summit to be held in New Delhi, officials said on Saturday. The summit will primarily focus on boosting cooperation in areas of economy and trade, agriculture, health, education, climate action, defence, space technology, energy, critical minerals and high-technologies, among others, they said.

Left, CITU hit out at Centre for post-poll labour code push

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Polit Bureau of the Communist Party of India (Marxist) and the Centre of Indian Trade Unions (CITU) have launched a scathing attack on the Narendra Modi-led Union Government following the formal operationalisation of the four controversial Labour Codes on May 8, 2026.

Labelling the move a “blueprint for virtual slavery,” the Left leadership has called

upon State Governments to bypass the Central Rules through legislative amendments.

In a strongly-worded statement, the CPI(M) accused the Centre of “deceptive modus operandi,” alleging that the Government intentionally delayed notifying the Final Central Rules until the conclusion of recent Assembly elections in four States and a Union Territory.

“Within just four days of the results, they have operationalised the Codes. This



exposes their predatory intent to favour corporate masters over the working class,” the party stated.

Echoing this sentiment, CITU General Secretary Elamaram Kareem has called for a nationwide “militant

Goa declares 82 lakh sqmt of land as No-Development Zone

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Panaji

In a major step toward environmental conservation, the Goa Government has declared more than 82 lakh square metres of land as a No-Development Zone (NDZ) to safeguard eco-sensitive regions and prevent unregulated construction on hills and mounds.

According to officials from the Town and Country Planning (TCP) Department, the decision was approved by the TCP Board and covers areas including Majorda, Gonsua, and several other locations. In total, over 82,85,000 square metres have been brought under the NDZ category.

The move is aimed at protecting hill slopes and mound



areas where unchecked construction activities have sparked ecological concerns. “Over 82 lakh square

metres have been declared as No-Development Zone,” an official communication stated, adding that the initiative seeks to curb the flattening of hills and preserve Goa's natural topography.

In another significant development for the State's environmental protection efforts, the Union Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change has

approved a proposal by the Goa Forest Department to declare 6.72 crore square metres of land along the Mandovi and Zuari riverbanks as eco-sensitive zones.

The approval empowers the State Government to restrict future development activities in these areas, which are considered crucial for preserving the fragile river ecosystem.

CBI coordinated Abhay Rana’s extradition from Portugal: Officials

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The CBI coordinated the extradition of Abhay Rana, facing an Interpol Red Notice and wanted by the Haryana Police for extortion, criminal intimidation and attempt to murder, from Portugal on Saturday, officials said.

In an operation, the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) coordinated with the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) and the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) to secure the extradition of Rana, who was brought back to the country on Saturday by a Haryana Police team.

“The subject, namely Abhay alias Abhay Rana, was wanted by Haryana Police in a number of criminal cases registered in Haryana, involving offences such as extortion, criminal intimidation, operation of an organised crime syndi-



cate, attempt to murder and issuance of life threats,” a CBI spokesperson said in a statement.

More than 160 wanted criminals have successfully been brought back to India in the last few years through coordination via Interpol channels, the officials said.

In the case concerned against Rana registered at Karnal, it was alleged that the subject, along with his associates, threatened local businessmen through social media platforms, including WhatsApp calls,

for payment of ransom, the statement said. “Those who failed to comply with the demands were assaulted by members of the syndicate. Upon completion of the investigation, a charge sheet has been filed against the subject before the competent court in the concerned case,” it added.

The CBI, which is the nodal body in India for all matters related to the Interpol, got the Red Notice issued against Rana, the officials said.

The notice alerts all the Interpol member-states worldwide to detain a fugitive wanted by another member-state.

“After the subject was geo-located and arrested by the Portuguese authorities, an extradition request was submitted to them. Following due legal process, the Portuguese authorities granted the extradition of the subject to India,” the statement said.

Hidden camera on railway signal sparks security alert in Vaishali

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Hajipur (Bihar)

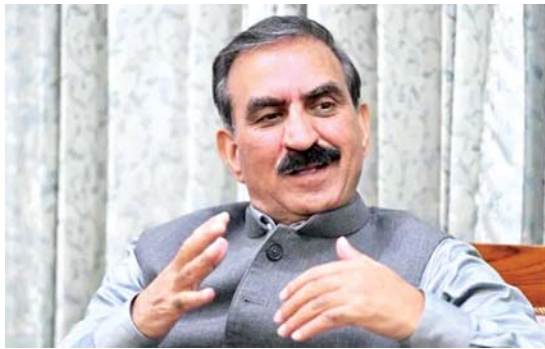
Security personnel were alarmed when they discovered a suspicious camera installed on a railway signal in Bihar's Vaishali district, officials said on Saturday.

The hidden camera, which had a SIM card, was set up on a railway signal near Sarai railway station. The Government Railway Police (GRP), Muzaffarpur section, has registered a case and is conducting further investigations into the matter.

“A suspicious camera was found installed on a railway signal near Sarai station on Friday. An investigation is on. Forensic experts have been examining the device. Those who installed the camera will soon be apprehended,” Superintendent of Police, GRP Muzaffarpur, Beena Kumari said.



States Focus



CM SUKHU CALLS FOR STUDY ON CLOUDBURST INCIDENTS

Chief Minister Sukhvir Singh Sukhu has directed the Himalayan Centre for Disaster Risk Reduction and Resilience at Himachal Pradesh University to undertake detailed scientific studies on the recurring cloudburst incidents in the State. He said the study should include an assessment of the impact of dams, temperature variations, and terrain conditions, besides an aerial distance-based analysis of the frequent cloudburst events in the Himalayan region, a statement issued here on Saturday said. Chairing a high-level meeting to discuss disaster risks, resilience planning and related research initiatives, he said the Himalayan centre would carry out state-level research and development activities related to disaster studies, hazard assessment and technical evaluations.



PEOPLE OF BENGAL HAPPIER THAN ME: SUVENDU'S MOTHER

Newly sworn-in Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari's mother Gayatri Adhikari on Saturday said the people of West Bengal are happier than she is over her son being at the helm of the first BJP Government in West Bengal. Suwendu Adhikari and five other BJP MLAs took the oath at the iconic Brigade Parade Grounds in Kolkata on Saturday in the presence of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Union Home Minister Amit Shah, the BJP's central leadership and chief ministers of NDA-ruled States.

Mamata urges Opposition to form joint platform against BJP

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Kolkata

After facing a drubbing in the juts concluded assembly elections, former West Bengal chief minister Mamata Banerjee on Saturday appealed to all Opposition parties to come together to form a "joint platform" to fight the BJP which came to power in the state after the recently held Assembly elections.

Announcing for a new journey for TMC on occasion of Tagore's birth anniversary, Mamata called upon the student unions of various affiliations opposed to the BJP and the NGOs and other stakeholders to unite against the BJP.

"I call upon all opposition parties, including the Leftists and the ultra-Left, to come together to form a joint platform against the BJP," the TMC supremo said on a day when the BJP's first government in the State was sworn in. TMC will now sit in opposition in



TMC supremo Mamata Banerjee pays tribute to Nobel laureate Rabindranath Tagore on his birth anniversary in Kolkata

PTI

the West Bengal assembly after remaining in power for 15 years since 2011.

The TMC chief said that she will talk with any political party if they want to hold a dialogue with her in this regard. "It is not the time to think the enemy's enemy is my friend, our first enemy is the BJP," she said, while addressing a small gathering in front of her Kalighat residence, while observing poet Rabindranath Tagore's birth anniversary.

She claimed that atrocities were being committed against TMC workers and supporters across the state following the declaration of the assembly election results. "Hooliganism is going on at places, bad elements have entered their (BJP) ranks," Mamata said as she claimed she did not allow atrocities against anyone after coming to power in 2011.

Stating that leaders of all opposition parties contacted her after the Bengal poll

results were declared, Mamata said, "Congress leaders Sonia Gandhi, Rahul Gandhi and party president Mallikarjun Kharge spoke to me."

Expressing gratitude to all of them, she said that other leaders like Shiv Sena UBT chief Uddhav Thackeray and RJD's Tejaswi Yadav sent messages to her, while SP leader Akhilesh Yadav came to Kolkata and met her following the results.

Banerjee said that Congress leaders and advocates Kapil Sibal and Abhishek Manu Singhvi, and TMC Rajya Sabha MP Menaka Guruswamy, who represented the TMC government in various matters before the Supreme Court as well in the Calcutta High Court, spoke to her over the phone to express their solidarity. "I am also a senior advocate enrolled in the Calcutta High Court Bar Association and the Bar Council of West Bengal," she said.

PM touches feet of BJP veteran at swearing-in

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Kolkata

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Saturday touched the feet of 98-year-old BJP veteran Makhanlal Sarkar and sought his blessings at the swearing-in ceremony of the party's first Government in West Bengal.

Sarkar was arrested in Kashmir in 1952 while accompanying Jana Sangh founder Syama Prasad Mookerjee during the movement to hoist the Indian tricolour there, the BJP said.

"Sarkar is one of the early grassroots figures associated with the nationalist movement in post-independence India," the



Prime Minister Narendra Modi greets senior BJP worker Makhanlal Sarkar during the swearing-in ceremony of party leader Suwendu Adhikari in Kolkata, West Bengal

PTI

party said in a statement. Felicitating Sarkar on the

stage at the Brigade Parade Grounds here before the oath-

taking ceremony of the Suwendu Adhikari government, the PM touched his feet to take his blessings and hugged the veteran leader before exchanging pleasantries. After the formation of the BJP in 1980, Sarkar became the organisational coordinator for the then West Dinajpur, Jalpaiguri and Darjeeling districts in Left Front-ruled West Bengal.

"From 1981 onward, he served continuously for seven years as district president, an exceptional achievement at a time when BJP leaders generally could not remain in the same organisational position for more than two years," the statement said.

TCS case: Owaisi decries media trial of Nida Khan

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar

All India Majlis E Ittehadul Muslimeen president Asaduddin Owaisi on Saturday said it was wrong to associate his party to TCS case accused Nida Khan and asserted the latter will be proven innocent in court.

Khan, a key accused in the TCS sexual harassment-forced conversion case, was arrested from Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar on Thursday by Nashik police, following which AIMIM corporator Matin Patel was booked for sheltering her while she was on the run.

The developments have evoked sharp reactions from ruling Mahayuti leaders, including ministers Sanjay Shirsat and Nitesh Rane, who have called for a deeper probe against the AIMIM in the case. Addressing reporters after a meeting of this party in connection with the upcoming Special Intensive Revision (SIR)



Asaduddin Owaisi

of electoral rolls in the state, Owaisi said Nida Khan is being subjected to a "media trial".

"Nida Khan was transferred from her job before the FIR was registered. We all have seen the statement of TCS. It says she is not connected in any manner to the HR department. Nine FIRs have been registered so far, and in one of them, Nida Khan has been named for allegedly hurting religious sentiments," he said.

Asserting that the complainant in the case is a "member of the ruling party",

the Lok Sabha MP questioned whether possession of a burqa or a book on Prophet Mohammad was illegal, adding that it is available in every Muslim household.

Earlier, in Delhi, police dubbed some youth as terrorists because a book of (legendary poet) Mirza Ghalib was found in their home, he pointed out.

"This is a media trial, and if the media acts like judge and jury, it is dangerous. It will not serve the purpose of justice. We have faith that the

court will deliver justice and the girl (Nida Khan) will be proven innocent. This case will not stand in court," Owaisi emphasised.

"This is being done with the intention to harass educated persons from the Muslim community. The allegations are coming out of hatred. The judiciary will play its role. But connecting a party with this case is completely wrong," he further said. On his party colleague and corporator, Matin Patel, being booked, Owaisi said the charges will be contested in court.

He claimed such an environment was created after the blasts in Malegaon and Mumbai, but no one went to the families of those incarcerated once the judgment (of acquittal) was delivered.

The allegations against his party in the case at least mean "we are not the B team of the BJP", the AIMIM chief added. A Special Investigation Team (SIT) of the Nashik

police is probing nine cases of molestation and harassment at the IT major's Nashik unit. It had arrested eight persons, including a female operations manager, by registering nine FIRs after allegations of exploitation, attempt of forceful conversion, hurting religious sentiments, molestation and mental harassment of female employees at the TCS unit came to light.

Nida Khan is accused of targeting employees in a WhatsApp group, pressuring them to pray and eat non-vegetarian food. According to the FIR, she also allegedly advised women employees to dress and behave in accordance with Islamic traditions.

TCS has clarified that it has adopted a zero-tolerance policy towards harassment and coercion of any form for a long time, and the employees allegedly involved in sexual harassment at the Nashik office have been suspended.

Kharge attacks Modi Govt for ending MGNREGA

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
New Delhi

Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge on Saturday accused the Modi Government of wiping out the rights of the poor as he slammed it for doing away with the MGNREGA and "finishing off the right to work".

Kharge accused the Bharatiya Janata Party-led Centre of having pre-planned the elimination of the right to work for the poor.

"The Modi Government, before killing the MGNREGA, had already strangled the 'Right to Work', torturing crores of poor people," he alleged in a post in Hindi on X. Kharge said according to a latest report, the number of families that received work under the Mahatma Gandhi National Rural



The Modi Government, before killing the MGNREGA, had already strangled the 'Right to Work', torturing crores of poor people — MALLIKARJUN KHARGE, CONGRESS PRESIDENT

Employment Guarantee Act (MGNREGA) dropped by 44 lakh in 2025-26, and that of labourers who got employment fell by 67 lakh.

The Congress chief also claimed that the number of families receiving full 100

days of employment dropped by 40.5 per cent and there was a 21.5-per cent decline in the number of person days. Every MGNREGA family has suffered an average income loss of Rs 1,221, he added.

34 years on, Gujarat Police crack woman's murder; 2 brothers held

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Ahmedabad

Thirty-four years after a woman was allegedly murdered and buried, the Gujarat police have arrested two brothers following the exhumation of skeletal remains from a house in Ahmedabad, an official said on Saturday.

The crime branch nabbed the accused, Shamshuddin Khedawala (61) and his brother Iqbal (63), in connection with a 1992 murder case, after DNA from the exhumed bones matched with siblings of the victim, Farzana Doshu Radhanpuri, he said.

The victim was Shamshuddin's wife, and the latter had allegedly killed her with the help of his brother and two others. They then buried the body in the pit in the veranda of a house in Qutub Nagar in the Vatva area, the official said. Acting on a tip-off, the



police dug at the site on April 29 to recover a jawbone and teeth, which were subsequently analysed by the Forensic Medicine Department at BJ Medical College to establish the victim's identity.

Following enquiries with locals, the police traced the victim's family to Dholka taluka, where her brother, Liyakat Ali, revealed she had been missing for 35 years. To confirm the identity, investigators compared DNA from the skeletal remains with blood samples from Farzana's sister, Mehbooba, resulting in a positive match, the official said. The family informed the

police that Farzana had left home 35 years ago and had later married Shamsuddin, he said.

Based on the information, the police registered a first information report (FIR) against the Khedawala brothers and one Abdul Javarawala and Shaliyabibi Pathan, both of whom are deceased. As per the FIR, Shamshuddin, along with his brother Iqbal, his friend Abdul Javarawala, and Shaliyabibi Pathan, allegedly killed Farzana and buried the body in a pit in the veranda and sealed it.

A case has been registered against all four accused under sections 302 (murder), 201 (destruction of evidence), and 120(B) (criminal conspiracy) of the Indian Penal Code, police said. The brothers have been arrested and will be produced in the court on Saturday. Deputy Commissioner of Police Ajit Rajian said.

KC Joseph criticises public tussle over Kerala CM post

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Kottayam (Kerala)

Senior Congress leader KC Joseph on Saturday criticised the public tussle by party supporters over the Kerala chief minister post, warning that taking internal matters to the streets could have dangerous consequences.

He was referring to protests, flex boards and posters put up by supporters of Congress leaders VD Satheesan, KC Venugopal and Ramesh Chennithala, who are being considered for the chief minister's post.

Joseph was a Congress MLA for 39 years, representing the Irikkur constituency in Kannur and had served as a minister in the Oommen Chandy-led UDF Government.

In a Facebook post, Joseph said he was remaining silent because "silence is preferable". He said everyone should realise that taking the internal affairs of the Congress onto the streets would create dangerous consequences.

Joseph also remarked that "if one spits while lying down,



Senior Congress leader KC Joseph

ACCORDING TO HIM, SUCH PUBLIC DISAGREEMENTS WOULD ULTIMATELY HARM THE PARTY ITSELF

it will fall on one's own face".

According to him, such public disagreements would ultimately harm the party itself. He further criticised the protest demonstrations held in Thiruvananthapuram, saying that they had hurt

many party supporters, as the image of former Chief Minister Oommen Chandy was allegedly torn, knowingly or unknowingly.

"This is not good for anyone. Trying to scratch one's head with a burning stick will be disastrous," he said in the post. The Congress won 63 seats of its own in the 140-member Assembly, while the United Democratic Front (UDF) alliance has won 102 seats, staging a comeback in the southern State.

FREEDOM OF EXPRESSION IS CONGRESS' BEAUTY, SAYS ABIN VARKEY

Pathanamthitta: Congress MLA-elect Abin Varkey on Saturday said that the party has always upheld freedom of expression, and he is not against workers installing flex boards in support of leaders being considered for the post of Kerala chief minister.

He was referring to protests and flex boards installed across Kerala in support of Congress leaders VD Satheesan, KC Venugopal and Ramesh Chennithala, who are being considered for the CM post. Speaking to reporters, Varkey said it was natural for Congress party workers to support leaders they admire by raising slogans and putting up flex boards. "In the Congress party, there is freedom to take the names of leaders in support, raise slogans for them and install flex boards. It was the same in the past, it is the same in the present, and it will remain so in the future. That is the beauty of the Congress," he said.

He said such freedom attracted people like him to the party despite the criticism. "I am not against installing flex boards of leaders, but against tearing them down. There is no need to destroy the flex boards of leaders. Similarly, attacks against each other on social media are unnecessary," he said. The Congress leader, who is also the state vice-president of the Youth Congress, said the party had never contested elections by projecting a chief ministerial face. "The chief minister is selected based on the situation. AICC observers arrive in the state and hold meetings with MLAs and leaders before submitting their report to the party high command," he said.

He said the regular procedure was followed in Kerala after the Assembly elections, with observers meeting MLAs and leaders to gather opinions before filing their report.



PROSPECT

DELHI MAYOR AND DEPUTY MAYOR FELICITATED



Elite Circle felicitated newly elected Delhi Mayor Pravesh Wahi and Deputy Mayor Dr Monika Pant. The event was attended by judges, leading industrialists, IAS, IRS officers, and other distinguished guests. Mayor Wahi assured that concrete steps would soon be taken to make Delhi clean, beautiful, and safe. Chairman Rakesh Gupta said that the people of Delhi have high expectations from the triple-engine Government.

CBI searches premises linked to cases against Anil Ambani's Reliance Group

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The CBI on Saturday conducted searches at 17 premises in Mumbai in connection with three cases registered against Reliance ADA Group companies Reliance Telecom Limited, Reliance Commercial Finance Limited and Reliance Home Finance Limited and their directors, officials said. "These searches are being conducted at the residential premises of directors of the above-mentioned companies as well as at the office premises of intermediary companies whose accounts were used for diversion of bank funds," a spokesperson for the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) said in a statement. No immediate reaction was available from the companies.

The CBI got a search warrant issued from a special court in Mumbai on Friday.



The searches have led to the seizure of incriminating documents, the officials said.

The total quantum of the alleged loss suffered by banks and the Life Insurance Company (LIC) of India in these cases is ₹27,337 crore, they added.

"Searches have also revealed that multiple intermediary companies were operating from same address. The investigation is continuing," the statement said.



RCom — joint president D Vishwanath, who was the overall in-charge of the group's banking operations, and vice-president Anil Kalya, who had actively supported Vishwanath in managing the banking operations and payments and utilisation of funds — on April 24.

"Both the accused persons are presently in judicial custody. The investigation into the cases relating to the Anil Ambani-led Reliance Group is being monitored by the Supreme Court," the statement said.

Army's K9 warriors display combat skills in slithering exercise



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kohima

K9 Warriors of the Red Shield Division of the Indian Army carried out a slithering exercise on May 8 at the Leimakhong Military Station in Manipur. Five dog teams participated in this highly specialised training aimed at enhancing rapid helicopter insertion capabilities, operational coordination,

combat readiness and synergy amongst troops during the challenging operational scenarios.

The exercise showcased professionalism, confidence and teamwork of the handlers and trained military dogs, highlighting their vital role in disaster management response, search and rescue operations and terrorist neutralisation missions.

PMJJBY, PMSBY settle claims worth ₹25,160 cr since their launch in 2015



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Jansuraksha schemes like Pradhan Mantri Jeevan Jyoti Bima Yojana and Pradhan Mantri Suraksha Bima Yojana have settled claims of about ₹25,160 crore since their launch in 2015, Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman said on Saturday. Jan Suraksha schemes Pradhan Mantri Jeevan Jyoti Bima Yojana (PMJJBY), Pradhan Mantri Suraksha Bima Yojana (PMSBY), and Atal Pension Yojana (APY) envisioned to extend affordable financial protection to all, particularly the under-served and vulnerable sections of society, were launched by Prime Minister Narendra Modi on May 9, 2015.

These flagship schemes, which completed 11 years, aim to broaden the insurance and pension landscape by shielding citizens against life's uncertainties and fostering long-term financial resilience.

Citing data on the 11th anniversaries of the Jan Suraksha Schemes, Sitharaman said that over 27 crore, 58 crore and 9 crore

enrolments have been done under PMJJBY, PMSBY and APY, respectively.

On PMJJBY, she said the scheme has settled claims worth more than ₹21,500 crore for over 10.7 lakh families. Under PMSBY scheme, Sitharaman said it has settled claims worth nearly ₹3,660 crore for over 1.84 lakh families.

"As we mark the 11th anniversary of the Jan Suraksha schemes, heartfelt appreciation for all the stakeholders, including field functionaries of banks and insurance companies, whose dedicated efforts have made these schemes a huge success," she said.

Speaking on the occasion, Minister of State for Finance Pankaj Chaudhary said the launch of the online Jan Suraksha Portal has made it possible for citizens to enrol conveniently without visiting bank branches or post offices, and the digitising the claims process has ensured faster settlements, enabling timely support to bereaved families when they need it the most.

"As we celebrate the 11th anniversaries of the three-



social security (Jan Suraksha) schemes -- PMJJBY, PMSBY and APY, let us recount how these schemes have enabled affordable insurance and security to people (Jan Suraksha), their achievements and salient features," he said.

Launched in 2015, PMJJBY offers life insurance cover for death due to any cause at an annual premium of ₹436. Eligible individuals between 18 and 50 years can enrol through participating banks or post offices. It provides ₹2 lakh to the nominee in the event of the subscriber's death.

As of April 29, the scheme has recorded 12.72 crore female enrolments and 8.09 crore enrolments from PMJDY account holders, the finance ministry said in a statement.

The PMSBY scheme offers accidental death and disability insurance to individuals aged 18 to 70 years at a nominal premium of ₹20 per annum.

The scheme pays ₹2 lakh for accidental death or total disability and ₹1 lakh for partial disability.

As on April 29, 2026, the

scheme has recorded 27.45 crore female enrolments and 19.30 crore enrolments from PMJDY account holders, it said.

Atal Pension Yojana aims to provide old-age income security to unorganised sector workers. It guarantees a monthly pension of ₹1,000 to ₹5,000 after the age of 60, depending on the contribution. The scheme is administered by the Pension Fund Regulatory and Development Authority (PFRDA) under the National Pension System (NPS) framework.

Open to bank account holders aged 18 to 40 years who are not income tax payers, the scheme has seen over 7.66 crore enrolments till April 2025.

Subscribers can choose monthly, quarterly, or half-yearly contribution modes.

In case of a subscriber's death before the age of 60, the spouse may continue contributing until the original retirement age or withdraw the accumulated corpus. As on April 30, 2026, more than 9.04 crore individuals have enrolled in the scheme, it added.

RBI officers' union seek governor's intervention to correct promotion policy

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

RBI officers' union has written a letter to RBI Governor Sanjay Malhotra, seeking his intervention to correct the promotion policy and restore a time-bound system.

RBI officers across various regional offices and the central bank's headquarters in Mumbai staged protests on Friday against recent policy changes that link promotions to vacancy availability, replacing the earlier time-bound promotion system.

Reserve Bank of India Officers' Association (RBIOA), in a letter dated May 8, expressed disappointment and anguish over the decision of the central bank to proceed with the revised promotion policy without adequately considering the serious concerns, objections, and constructive suggestions repeatedly placed by the association on behalf of the officer community.

The revised policy, in its present form, has caused widespread dissatisfaction, frustration and demoralisation among officers across cadres and grades, it added.

Citing past interactions with officers at various regional offices, it said that you (Governor) had indicated the possibility of a few time-bound promotions.

However, the final policy has not only failed to address the structural stagnation prevailing across grades but has also disregarded the core concerns repeatedly highlighted by the association, it pointed



out. According to an estimate, about 8,000 officers working at the RBI are going to be impacted by the change in the promotion policy.

Stagnation is rising across the various levels, leading to frustration, particularly among younger officers, who are now confronted with the prospect of remaining in the same grade for prolonged periods without meaningful progression, it said. "We earnestly request the top management to reconsider the matter urgently and initiate a comprehensive review of the revised promotion policy in consultation with RBIOA so as to arrive at a fair, balanced and sustainable framework for career progression of officers," it noted.

The association demanded that the newly issued promotion policy be immediately kept in abeyance and reviewed comprehensively in consultation with RBIOA through a structured and meaningful consultation mechanism.

It also demanded that the assured, time-bound promotions may be intro-

duced across all cadres from Grade A to Grade E, ensuring fair and predictable career progression for officers.

The principle of 'One Grade, One Allowance' may be introduced across grades by removing the existing condition of a minimum of five years' service in a grade for eligibility to facilities, allowances and entitlements attached to that grade, it said.

The letter further said that the association submits that the above measures are not merely matters of financial benefit but are essential for restoring morale, institutional trust and long-term organisational commitment among officers.

A motivated and professionally secure officer community remains indispensable to preserving the excellence, independence and effectiveness of the Reserve Bank of India, it added.

It is to be noted that the officers of another financial sector regulator, the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi), had also staged a protest in 2024 to press for wage-related issues.

ED arrests three in cryptocurrency linked PMLA case



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bengaluru

The Enforcement Directorate has arrested three persons, including an alleged crypto hacker named Srikrishna Ramesh alias Sriki, in a cryptocurrency-linked money laundering case, officials said on Saturday.

They said Sriki, Robin Khandelwal and Sunish Hegde were taken into custody on May 8. They were produced before a local Bengaluru court on Saturday, which sent them to 10 days of ED custody, officials said.

The central agency conducted raids in this case on April 20, including at premises linked to the accused Mohammed Haris Nalapad and Omar Farook Nalapad, sons of Karnataka Congress MLA N A Haris, and Aqeeb Khan, grandson of veteran Congress leader and former Union minister K Rahman Khan, among others.

Mohammed Haris Nalapad, a former Karnataka Youth Congress President, later interacted with the press and denied any wrongdoing, asserting that the 21 hours of search by the ED in his and his brother's house did not yield anything.

He said his family had been in public life for a long time and that their conduct was upright.

India exports first-ever ODOP honey from Assam to USA

TONY DAS
■ Guwahati

In a significant boost to India's agri-export landscape and the promotion of the One District One Product (ODOP) initiative, the first-ever export of ODOP Honey from the Aspirational District of Baksa, Assam to the United States of America was flagged off through the initiative of APEDA on May 9. The consignment was undertaken by an APEDA-registered exporter, Salt Range Foods Pvt. Ltd., Assam.

The landmark consignment, comprising approximately 20 metric tonnes of honey, was flagged off from Guwahati, Assam. The honey has been processed and packed at the facility of Salt Range Foods Private Limited in Guwahati.

Assam has immense potential for honey production owing to its rich biodiversity, abundant forest resources and long-standing tradition of beekeeping. Honey collection in Assam has been practised for centuries by indigenous communities such as the Karbi, Mishong and Bodo tribes, where it has traditionally been used as food, medicine and in cultural and religious



practices. Major honey-producing districts in the state include Baksa, Kokrajhar, Chirang, Udalguri and Tamulpur in the Bodoland Territorial Region (BTR). Assam produced approximately 1,650 metric tonnes of honey during FY 2023-24, as per National Horticulture Board latest data.

Sourced from eco-friendly and pesticide-free environments, the honey from Baksa district is known for its high quality and near-organic characteristics, reflecting the region's rich biodiversity and sustainable agricultural practices.

Honey from Baksa has also been identified under the ODOP initiative, recognising its strong potential for liveli-

hood generation, value addition and export growth. Baksa honey is widely known for its natural purity, rich floral diversity and high nutritional and medicinal value.

The ODOP initiative, aligned with the Government of India's vision of promoting district-specific products, aims to identify, brand and promote one product from each district to enhance value addition, create employment opportunities and strengthen local economies. By linking such products to global markets, the initiative plays a crucial role in diversifying India's export basket and empowering farmers and local producers.

The Agricultural and Processed Food Products Export Development Authority (APEDA), under the Ministry of Commerce & Industry, Government of India, facilitated the export by supporting infrastructure development, including the provision of testing and laboratory equipment at the processing facility to ensure adherence to international quality standards and food safety requirements.

The initiative is expected to significantly benefit local beekeepers and farmers, with farmers receiving approximately 43 per cent higher price realisation compared to prevailing local farm gate prices, thereby enhancing income opportunities and strengthening rural livelihoods in the region.

This export initiative marks a significant milestone in integrating farmers from Aspirational Districts into global value chains, ensuring better price realisation and sustained market access. It also highlights the growing export potential of the Northeast region, particularly in niche and value-added agricultural products.

APEDA reiterated its commitment in promoting

farmer-led exports, strengthening quality infrastructure and supporting initiatives such as ODOP to position India as a reliable supplier of high-quality agricultural products in global markets.

The ceremonial flag-off was led by the Chief Guest, Aruna Rajoria, IAS, Commissioner & Secretary to the Govt. of Assam Agriculture Department and Agriculture Production Commissioner, in the presence of Chairman APEDA Abhishek Dev, IAS and Virendra Mittal, IAS, State Project Director (SPD), ARIAS Society.

The programme was also graced by the presence of Narendra Kumar Shah, IAS, Commissioner, Industry and Commerce Department, Govt. of Assam, Ratul Pathak, ACS, Director of Agriculture Kinnei Changsan, IAS, District Commissioner, Baksa, Dr Sudhanshu, Secretary APEDA, Vinita Sudhanshu, General Manager, Sandeep Saha, Regional Head, APEDA RO NER, Manash Das, ACS, Secretary, BTC, Nripen Das, Director of Horticulture, Loken Das, Chief General Manager, NABARD Assam, DAO Baksa, officials from KVIC and other dignitaries.

Indo-Uzbek academic meeting highlights Space Tech in agriculture

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

In a significant move to bolster international academic ties, the MERI Centre for International Studies hosted a high-level delegation from Uzbekistan on Saturday to explore collaborative frontiers in research, innovation, and specifically, space technology.

The delegation, comprising senior officials from Bukhara State University (BSU) and Samarkand State University of Veterinary Medicine, Livestock and Biotechnologies, met with Indian academic leaders to bridge the gap between traditional research and modern technological applications.

A primary focus of the diplomatic exchange was the integration of space technology into the agricultural and livestock sectors. Lt General PJS Pannu (Retd), Chief Mentor and Dean of the Department of Space Studies at MERI, detailed how satellite-based innovations are revolutionizing land development.

The discussions highlighted several critical applica-



tions of space science for the modern farmer like Precision Agriculture for Utilizing satellite-based practices for enhanced crop yields; Environmental Monitoring to leverage space tech for soil analysis and real-time climate monitoring and Advanced Research for collaborative opportunities in Geographic Information Systems (GIS), Artificial Intelligence (AI), and military space studies.

Prof. Lalit Aggarwal, Vice-President of MERI Group of Institutions, and Prof. Ramakant Dwivedi opened the session by reaffirming

the organization's commitment to global innovation. Representing the Uzbek side, Dr Abror Juraev of BSU expressed a keen interest in academic collaboration, noting that his university—a classical institution covering nearly all disciplines—is currently undergoing a state-supported expansion.

Tolip Taylako, Vice-Rector at Samarkand State University, further emphasized that the future of Uzbekistan's economy relies heavily on the synergy between veterinary medicine and innovative space-based livestock development.

FROM THE

WORLD

COLORADO

Frontier plane hits pedestrian

A Frontier Airlines plane hit a pedestrian on the runway of the Denver International Airport during takeoff, airport authorities said, sparking an engine fire and forcing passengers to evacuate. The plane, on route from Denver to Los Angeles International Airport, "reported striking a pedestrian during takeoff at DEN at approximately 11.19 pm.", the airport's official X account wrote. Neither the airport nor the airline has disclosed the pedestrian's condition. "We're stopping on the runway," the pilot tells the control tower according to the site ATC.com. "We just hit somebody. We have an engine fire." The pilot tells the air traffic controller they have "231 souls" on board and that and "individual was walking across the runway".

USA

Rubio defends Cuba sanctions

Rubio defends new US sanctions on Cuba
US Secretary of State Marco Rubio defended the Trump administration's decision to slap new sanctions on Cuba, the largest of which is against GAESA, or Grupo de Administracion Empresarial SA, a business conglomerate operated by the Cuban Revolutionary Armed Forces. In addition to GAESA and its leader, the sanctions announced Thursday included Moa Nickel, a Cuban joint venture with Canada's Sheritt International, which immediately announced it would withdraw from the business, ending a 32-year presence on the island. The May 1 executive order and the new designations announced May 7 significantly expand the legal authority through which the US Government can levy sanctions on third-country nationals and firms, explained Lee Schlenker, a research associate at the Quincy Institute's Global South program.

US plans higher minimum wages for H1B

SAGAR KULKARNI
■ Washington

The US has proposed to increase the minimum wages paid to hire an employee under the H1B visa programme by 30 per cent over the previously fixed limits, a move the administration claims will help prevent foreigners from undercutting the salaries of US nationals.

The new rule, proposed by the US Department of Labour on March 27, seeks to increase the minimum wages for four categories from the entry-level to the most-experienced, contending that the existing wage levels were fixed 20 years ago and fail to adequately protect



President Donald Trump speaking to reporters as he walks to board Marine One on the South Lawn of the White House, in Washington

US workers. According to the proposed rule 'Improving Wage Protections for the Temporary and Permanent Employment of Certain Foreign Nationals in the

United States', the prevailing wage for entry-level foreign workers was \$73,279 per annum, \$98,987 (Level II), \$121,979 (Level III) and \$144,202 (Level IV).

The new rule, which is now open to public comments till May 26, seeks to increase the prevailing wages for entry-level workers to \$97,746, a hike of 33.39 per cent over the old rates, \$123,212 (Level II, 24.47 per cent), \$147,333 (Level III, 20.79 per cent), and \$175,464 (Level IV, 21.68 per cent). The prevailing wages differ from city to city. According to the Department of Labour, the current methodology allows employers to hire foreigners at wage levels significantly below those paid to similarly employed US citizens.

The proposed changes will dramatically increase the prevailing wage levels used in the H1B, H1B1, E-3, and PERM labour certifica-

tion programmes. The proposed rules have received mixed responses, ranging from overwhelming support to opposition, contending that smaller companies may no longer be able to hire freshers for entry-level jobs, given the higher prevailing wages.

The window for public comments closes on May 26 following which the Department of Labour will examine the responses and notify the final rule.

The Trump administration, in its first term, had initiated changes to the prevailing wages in 2020 without prior notice or comments, and the move had to be shelved after it ran into legal challenges. (PTI)

India, IOM discuss expanding regular migration pathways



YOSHITA SINGH
■ United Nations

India and the International Organisation for Migration (IOM) discussed expanding and diversifying regular migration pathways.

Minister of State for External Affairs Kirti Vardhan Singh met with IOM Director General Amy Pope on Friday on the sidelines of the second International Migration Review Forum (IMRF) of the Global Compact for Migration (GCM) currently underway.

"Discussions focused on expanding and diversifying regular migration pathways and on India's proactive approach to the implementation of GCM and IOM activities in India," Singh said in a social media post.

IOM is the leading UN-related intergovernmental organisation in the field of migration, established in 1951 to promote humane and orderly migration. It provides humanitarian assistance, manages migration flows,

and supports displaced populations worldwide.

Singh also met Minister of Immigration, Refugees and Citizenship of Canada Lena Metlege Diab.

"Discussions focused on the Canada-India Migration Initiative and areas of mutual interests in mobility of skilled workforce and students," he said. Singh, who arrived here Sunday, is leading the Indian delegation for the Second International Migration Review Forum, being held under the auspices of the UN General Assembly from May 4-8.

On Thursday, he met UN Secretary General Antonio Guterres at the UN headquarters, describing it as a "productive meeting".

Singh had delivered India's national statement at the Plenary session of the IMRF and addressed a side-event organised by the Permanent Mission of India to the UN titled, 'Leveraging Digital Innovation in Migration Governance-The e-Migrate Experience of India'. (PTI)

Jaishankar, Trinidad PM explore new ideas to expand bilateral cooperation

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Port of Spain

External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar held comprehensive talks with Trinidad and Tobago Prime Minister Kamla Persad-Bissessar to explore new ideas and initiatives for expanding bilateral cooperation between India and the dual-island nation.

Jaishankar arrived in Port of Spain from Paramaribo on Friday on the concluding leg of his three-nation tour of Jamaica, Suriname, and Trinidad and Tobago, aimed at deepening India's engagement with the



Caribbean nations. "Sat down this evening with PM Kamla Persad-Bissessar and her Cabinet colleagues for a comprehensive review of our bilateral ties," Jaishankar said in a social media post on Friday. "While delivering on the commitments made by PM Modi last year, we explored new ideas and initiatives in our bilateral cooperation," he said.

Earlier in the day, Jaishankar joined Persad-Bissessar at an event for the distribution of Made-in-India laptops to school-children, describing it as the fulfilment of a commitment made by PM Modi.

Nepal's acting CJ Malla cautions efforts to make judiciary obedient institution

SHIRISH B PRADHAN ■ Kathmandu

Acting Chief Justice of Nepal Sapana Pradhan Malla on Saturday called co-justices to carry out their duties impartially, free from fear, pressure or political influence.

Malla's remarks come two days after the Constitutional Council, headed by Prime Minister Balendra Shah, picked Dr Manoj Kumar Sharma as the new Chief Justice of Nepal, undermining the established practice and seniority protocol.

Addressing a special programme organised here to mark the 74th Law Day, Malla said, the essence of justice must not be undermined by the pressure of a two-thirds majority government or threats of impeachment. Addressing judges on the occasion, she urged them to work with high morale and integrity. "Justice cannot prevail under fear or influence," she added. "Whether it is the fear of a powerful government or the threat of impeachment, judges



must rise above such narrow constraints," Malla added. She called on the judicial fraternity to uphold the sanctity of justice with courage and impartiality, stressing that fearless decision-making is essential for safeguarding the independence and dignity of the judiciary.

Reflecting on her personal journey, Malla said she has been fighting discrimination and injustice for decades since she chose the legal profession.



Indian Ocean Ship (IOS) Sagar arriving at Chattogram, Bangladesh on 8 May, as it aims to strengthen maritime cooperation and professional ties between the Indian Navy and the Bangladesh Navy

Indian sailor killed in dhow fire near Hormuz

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

An Indian sailor was killed and several others injured after their wooden dhow caught fire near the Strait of Hormuz, government sources said on Saturday.

Seventeen other Indian crew members were rescued following the incident on Friday, they said, noting that the exact cause of the blaze is still being ascertained.

The crew members were rescued by a vessel that was passing by in the area, the sources said.

The incident came amid increasing hostilities between Iran and the US in the Strait of Hormuz, a vital maritime chokepoint between the Persian Gulf



and the Gulf of Oman through which a significant portion of the world's oil supply passes.

If confirmed as a casualty of the ongoing conflict, this latest death brings the total number of Indian fatalities to nine since hostilities broke out on February 28.

"A wooden Dhow, carrying general cargo, with 18 Indian

crew capsised yesterday close to the Strait of Hormuz after it caught fire," said a source. "In this incident, one Indian on the dhow died while four received burn injuries.

The injured are receiving medical treatment in Dubai and are safe," the source said. Officials from the Indian Consulate in Dubai met the

rescued Indian nationals on Friday night, said another source. The consulate is also in touch with the dhow owner and is extending all possible assistance, the sources said.

Before this incident, eight Indian nationals have been killed in the West Asia conflict, while dozens more have been injured across the region. In March, an Indian national was killed and another was injured by debris from the interception of a missile in the UAE capital of Abu Dhabi. An Indian national died in an Iranian attack on a power and water desalination plant in Kuwait in March. Another Indian national was killed in missile and drone attacks on the Saudi Arabian capital of Riyadh on March 18.

Israeli drone strikes near Beirut kill 4

BASSEM MROUE
■ Beirut

Three Israeli drone strikes on vehicles just south of Beirut on Saturday killed four people while a series of airstrikes on southern Lebanon killed at least 13, including a man and his 12-year-old daughter, state media and the Health Ministry said.

The three drone strikes south of Beirut marked another escalation since a ceasefire between Israel and Hezbollah went into effect on April 17. Both Israel and Hezbollah have continued their daily attacks despite the truce. On Wednesday night, Israel's air force carried out an airstrike on a southern suburb in which



Lebanese soldier standing next to a damaged vehicle at the scene of an Israeli airstrike that hit a car in the coastal town of Saadiyat, Lebanon

Israel said it killed a senior Hezbollah military official. It was the first strike near the capital since the ceasefire was reached.

Two of the strikes on Saturday took place on the

highway linking Beirut with the southern port city of Sidon in which several people were wounded, while the third happened on a road leading to Lebanon's Chouf region killing three,

the state-run National News Agency said. An Associated Press journalist at the scene saw a dead body on the highway in the town of Saadiyat. The Health Ministry said an Israeli airstrike on the southern village of Saksakiyeh killed at least seven, including a child, and wounded 15. The ministry said this was an initial count.

The agency reported strikes in southern Lebanon, including one on the village of Bourj Rahhal that killed three and another in Maifadoun that killed one.

The Health Ministry, meanwhile, said three Israeli drone strikes killed a Syrian man who was riding a motorcycle with his 12-year-old daughter in the city of Nabatiyeh. (AP)

WHO head will oversee evacuation of passengers, crew from hantavirus-stricken cruise ship

IAIN SULLIVAN/ ELENA BECATOROS
■ Tenerife

The head of the World Health Organisation arrived in Spain on Saturday to oversee the evacuation of more than 140 passengers and crew from a hantavirus-stricken cruise ship headed to the Canary Islands.

WHO Director-General Tedros Adhanom Ghebreyesus said he would be heading to the Spanish island of Tenerife off the coast of West Africa, along with senior Spanish government officials, "to oversee safe disembarkation of the passengers, crew members and health experts." The Dutch-flagged ship, the MV Hondius, is expected to arrive in Tenerife in



the early hours of Sunday. Tedros said that at this point, nobody on board the Hondius was showing symptoms of the virus.

"WHO continues to actively monitor the situation, coordinate support and next steps and will keep Member States and the

public updated accordingly. So far, the risk for the population of Canary Islands and globally remains low," he posted on X. Spain's Health Minister Monica Garcia said on Friday she would be heading to Tenerife with Tedros and Interior Fernando Grande-Marlaska to coordinate the disembarkation.

Passengers will be isolated

Three people have died since the outbreak, and five passengers who left the ship are infected with hantavirus. Both the US and the UK have agreed to send planes to evacuate their citizens from the cruise ship.

The head of Spain's emergency services, Virginia Barcones, has

said passengers will be taken to a "completely isolated, cordoned-off area" once they disembark.

Hantavirus is usually spread by the inhalation of contaminated rodent droppings and isn't easily transmitted between people. But the Andes virus detected in the cruise ship outbreak may be able to spread between people in rare cases. Symptoms usually show between one and eight weeks after exposure.

According to a letter sent by the Dutch foreign and health ministers to parliament late Friday, Spain has activated the EU civil protection mechanism for a medical evacuation plane equipped for high-consequence infectious disease to be on standby. In case anyone falls

ill, the medics on board the ship will inform the Spanish authorities, and the evacuation plane will be sent to Tenerife so that the sick person can be quickly transported by air to the European mainland. The Dutch government will work with Spanish authorities and the ship company to arrange repatriation of Dutch passengers and crew as soon as possible after arrival in Tenerife, subject to medical conditions and advice from the European Centre for Disease Prevention and Control, the letter said.

Those without symptoms will go into home quarantine for six weeks and be monitored by local health services. As the ship is Dutch-flagged, the Netherlands

may also temporarily accommodate people of other nationalities and monitor them in quarantine.

Health authorities across four continents were tracking down and monitoring more than two dozen passengers who disembarked before the deadly outbreak was detected.

On Friday, the WHO said a flight attendant on a plane briefly boarded by an infected cruise passenger had tested negative for hantavirus. Her possible infection had raised concerns about the virus' potential transmissibility. The flight attendant's negative result should ease concerns among the public, said Christian Lindmeier, a WHO spokesman. (AP)



Vladimir Putin vows Ukraine win at scaled-down Victory Day parade

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Moscow

Russian President Vladimir Putin on Saturday voiced confidence of victory in Ukraine as he oversaw a military parade on Red Square commemorating the defeat of Nazi Germany in World War II - a show that didn't include heavy weapons for the first time in nearly two decades. Security was tight in Moscow as Putin and several foreign leaders attended the parade, which was scaled down even as a US-brokered three-day ceasefire eased concerns about possible Ukrainian attempts to disrupt the festivities.

Putin, in power for more than a quarter-century, has used Victory Day, Russia's most important secular holiday, to showcase the country's military might and rally support for his military action in Ukraine, now in its fifth year. Speaking at the parade, Putin hailed Russian troops fighting in Ukraine, declaring that they "face an aggressive force that is armed and supported by the entire bloc of NATO".

"Victory has always been and will be ours," Putin said as columns of troops lined up on Red Square. "The key to success is our moral strength, courage and valour, our unity and ability to endure anything and overcome any challenge." But in a notable shift this year, the parade took place without tanks, missiles and other heavy equipment,



Russia's MiG-29 jet fighters of the Strizhi (Swifts) and Su-30SM jet fighters of the Russkiye Vityazi (Russian Knights) aerobatic teams fly over Red Square during the Victory Day military parade in Moscow

aside from a traditional flyover of combat jets. Officials explained the sudden change of format by the "current operational situation" and said that additional security measures have been taken in response to the threat of Ukrainian attacks. For the first time, Saturday's parade featured troops from North Korea, a tribute to Pyongyang that sent its soldiers to fight alongside Moscow forces to repel a Ukrainian incursion into Russia's Kursk region. Russia declared a unilateral ceasefire for Friday and Saturday, while Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy announced a truce that was supposed to begin on May 6, but neither of them held as the parties traded

blame for continuing attacks. US President Donald Trump announced on Friday that Russia and Ukraine have bowed to his request for a ceasefire running Saturday through Monday and an exchange of prisoners, declaring that the break in fighting could be the "beginning of the end" of the war. Zelenskyy, who said earlier this week that the Russian authorities "fear drones may buzz over Red Square" on May 9, followed up on Trump's statement by issuing a decree mockingly permitting Russia to hold its Victory Day celebrations on Saturday, declaring Red Square temporarily off-limits for Ukrainian strikes. The Russian Defence Ministry warned the civilian

population there and employees of foreign diplomatic missions of "the need to leave the city promptly". Putin has used Victory Day celebrations to encourage national pride and underline Russia's position as a global power. The Soviet Union lost 27 million people in 1941-45 in what it calls the Great Patriotic War, an enormous sacrifice that left a deep scar in the national psyche and remains a rare point of consensus in the nation's divisive history under Communist rule. "We celebrate it with feelings of pride and love for our country, with understanding of our shared duty to defend the interests and future of our Motherland," Putin said at the parade.

Top Sri Lankan monk arrested for alleged sexual abuse of minor girl



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Colombo

One of Sri Lanka's senior most Buddhist monks has been arrested for the sexual abuse of a minor girl, the police said on Saturday. Venerable Pallegama Hemarathana, 71, is the chief priest of a prominent temple in the country. He was taken into custody on Friday night after a magistrate's court in the holy city of Anuradhapura issued an arrest warrant against him and the victim's mother for allegedly aiding and abetting child abuse. The victim is a girl who is now 15 years old, according to the police, who was allegedly abused in the premises of a temple in Anuradhapura, police spokesperson FT Woodtler told reporters. A complaint about the incident was registered in March. It was initially about abduction and detention of a minor, reported the Daily Mirror media portal.

Trump-Xi talks next week may decide activist Jimmy Lai's fate

KANIS LEUNG
■ Hong Kong

Pro-democracy activist Jimmy Lai once hoped US President Donald Trump could help stop the imposition of a controversial national security law. The law not only took effect but was also used to sentence him to 20 years in prison. Ahead of an anticipated trip by Trump to Beijing to meet Chinese President Xi Jinping next week, Lai's son said his family is now hoping that Trump can help secure his father's release. Lai, a prominent critic of Beijing, founded a pro-democracy newspaper that was shut down during a crackdown following the



city's massive anti-Government protests in 2019. Observers say the former media mogul's plight symbolises a decline in freedoms Beijing promised when the former British colony returned to Chinese rule in 1997. In an interview with The Associated Press, Sebastien Lai said he fears the clock is ticking for his 78-year-old father. Trump is expected to discuss trade, the Iran war and Taiwan with Xi. But he said he is also planning to bring up Lai, telling conservative radio host Hugh Hewitt, "there's a little bitterness, I would say, with him and Jimmy Lai." The younger

Magyar becomes Hungary's PM, ending Orban's era

JUSTIN SPIKE
■ Budapest

Hungary's Peter Magyar took his oath of office on Saturday to become the country's new prime minister, ending Viktor Orban's 16 years of autocratic rule. Magyar's centre-right Tisza party defeated Orban's nationalist-populist Fidesz in a stunning blow last month, gaining more votes and seats in Parliament than any other party in Hungary's post-Communist history. The win, which gave Tisza a two-thirds parliamentary majority, will allow it to roll back many of the policies that gave Orban a reputation among his critics as a far-right authoritarian. In a speech to lawmakers in



Hungary's Parliament after being sworn in, Magyar said he would not use his office to "rule" Hungary, "but to serve my homeland." "I'm not standing here because I'm different from anyone else in the country," Magyar said. "I stand here because millions of Hungarians decided that

down on alleged corruption. His government is expected to transform political dynamics within the European Union, where the former prime minister had upended the bloc by frequently vetoing key decisions, most recently concerning support for neighbouring Ukraine. Magyar, a 45-year-old lawyer who founded Tisza in 2024 after years as an insider in Orban's party, entered the sprawling neo-Gothic parliament building alongside 140 of his party representatives. Tisza now controls 141 seats in Hungary's 199-seat parliament. Orban's Fidesz-KDNP coalition controls 52 seats, down from 135, while the far-right Mi Hazank party holds six seats. (AP)

Indonesian rescuers find one body after volcano eruption as search continues

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Jakarta

Rescuers on Saturday recovered the body of an Indonesian woman who was caught in a volcanic eruption at Mount Dukono on Indonesia's remote island of Halmahera a day earlier, as search operations continued to find the bodies of two Singaporeans, officials said. The slain hikers were among 20 who set out to ascend the 1,355-metre (4,445-foot) volcano in defiance of safety restrictions and became stranded when Dukono erupted early Friday, spewing a



thick ash column that rose about 10 kilometres (6 miles) into the air. The woman, identified by authorities only as Enjel and known as a local hiker, was located on Saturday

afternoon, about 50 metres (165 feet) from the rim of the main crater, said Iwan Ramdani, who heads the local Search and Rescue Office. The location of the bodies of two Singaporean climbers remains unknown, and rescue teams are continuing operations amid high volcanic activity, he said. "The rescue efforts went through a situation that required careful calculation and a well-planned evacuation strategy," Ramdani said, "We took into account the potential escalation of volcanic activity as well as the safety of all personnel."

Pak security forces kill 5 terrorists in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Peshawar

Five terrorists were killed in operations conducted by security forces in Pakistan's restive Khyber Pakhtunkhwa province, the army said on Saturday. Based on intelligence reports, the security forces initiated two separate operations in the Tank and Dera Ismail Khan districts on May 7 and 8, it said in a statement. Four terrorists belonging to the banned Tehreek-e-Taliban Pakistan (TTP) were killed in the military engagement in the Tank district, the statement said. In Dera Ismail Khan, another TTP member was killed in an exchange of fire with the security forces. Weapons and ammunition have also been recovered from the possession of the slain terrorists, the statement said. Pakistan has witnessed a surge in terrorist attacks, especially in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa and Balochistan provinces, predominantly targeting the police, law enforcement agencies' personnel, and security forces. (AP)

UK PM appoints advisers after local election losses

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ London

British Prime Minister Keir Starmer on Saturday appointed two veteran leaders in expert advisory roles at Downing Street after a disastrous local election for the governing Labour Party. Former British prime minister and chancellor Gordon Brown was named Special Envoy on Global Finance and Cooperation and former party leader and Cabinet minister Harriet Harman as Adviser on Women and Girls. The appointment of two senior party grandees came a day after Labour's worst local election performance, losing hundreds of key



strongholds across councils in England and ceding control of the devolved Welsh Parliament - casting a long shadow over the future of Starmer's leadership. "On both fronts (Brown and Harman) they are very future-looking roles, they're vital to how we strengthen our country and take it forward," Starmer told reporters. "We have to set out the path ahead and that's what I intend to do in the coming days - how we rebuild, how we convince people about hope for the future. And we haven't done enough of

that," he said. He reiterated that he did not intend to walk away and "plunge the country into chaos" following the "tough" election results. "We made unnecessary mistakes. One of which was that we, rightly in my view, levelled with the public about the challenges that we face as a country, both on the finances and internationally. But what we didn't do enough is to convince them about the change that would impact them, how their lives would be better. The hope wasn't there enough in the first two years of this government. "I think the right thing to do is to rebuild and show the path forward," he said.

Three Indian-origin men convicted of couple's first-degree murder in Canada

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Abbotsford (Canada)

Three Indian-origin persons have been found guilty of first-degree murder by a court in Canada in connection with the killing of a couple in Abbotsford, according to local broadcaster CBC News. Arnold and Joanne De Jong were found dead in their Abbotsford residence in May 2022. Four years later, British Columbia Supreme Court Justice Brenda Brown on Friday ruled that Gurkaran Singh, Abhijeet Singh and Khushveer Toor played a willing and integral role in the couple's murder, the broad-



caster reported. The judge agreed with prosecutors that the murders were financially motivated and rejected defence arguments that the deaths resulted from a robbery that went wrong, the report said. Prosecutors told the court the three men had jointly

Vatican sending new signals of openness but limitations in outreach to LGBTQ+ Catholics

NICOLE WINFIELD
■ Vatican City

The Vatican is sending new signals about how it intends to minister to LGBTQ+ Catholics in the Pope Leo XIV era, with signs of openness and limitations after Pope Francis ushered in a notable welcome during his 12-year pontificate. Catholic LGBTQ+ advocates cheered this week when a Vatican working group released a report featuring the testimony of two gay, married Catholics who spoke openly about their sexuality, faith and how the Catholic Church's negative teaching on homosexuality had hurt them. Additionally, Leo made clear during a recent air-

borne news conference that he believed the church's teachings on social justice, equality and freedom were far more important than its teaching on sexual morality, suggesting he doesn't intend to prioritise the issue. At that same news conference, though, Leo indicated he will go no further than Francis on the contentious matter of same-sex blessings. The Vatican has recently renewed its opposition to any local efforts to deviate from the Holy See stance. For the Rev James Martin, an American Jesuit who has spearheaded the church's outreach to the LGBTQ+ community in the US, the developments signal strong continuity with Francis. "If the

Catholic Church has begun to listen to LGBTQ Catholics as part of its methodology, the church has already moved forward in a significant way," he wrote recently. But the signals have prompted criticism from conservatives, who have stressed official Catholic teaching - unchanged during even Francis' pontificate - that says homosexual activity is "intrinsically disordered". The Vatican working group report summarised the work of experts studying controversial topics that emerged after Francis' yearslong reform effort. The report has no binding value and is merely a synthesis of deliberations. It's not clear what, if anything, Leo will do with it. The testimony of the gay



men, contained in annexes published on the Vatican's synod website, featured moving accounts of how one, from Portugal, came to terms with his homosexuality and

married his husband. The man also recounted how he sometimes struggled with his faith because of insensitive remarks from a Catholic spiritual director and

forced "conversion therapy," the scientifically discredited practice of using therapy to "convert" LGBTQ+ people to heterosexuality or traditional gender expectations.

The other testimony, from an American, criticised the therapy he went through and counselling he received from a Catholic pastoral group, Courage, that seeks to help people with same-sex attraction live chastely. "My sexuality isn't a perversion, disorder, or cross; it's a gift from God," the person wrote. Courage, in a statement Friday, decried the negative depiction of its work, saying it has never been involved in "reparative therapy". "Courage has suffered calumny and detraction before, but usually from secular outlets," the group said. "It is a great sadness and an additional wound to our members to have this false and unjust depiction in a

Vatican document." Martin said the publication marked the first time that an official Vatican report "has included such detailed stories from LGBTQ Catholics. As such, it marks a significant step forward in the church's relationship with the LGBTQ community." Bishop Joseph Strickland, whom Francis removed as bishop of Tyler, Texas, said the report was "deeply alarming" and contradicted church teaching about sexuality, sin, marriage and morality. In a post on his personal website entitled "An Emergency in the Church," Strickland said the church's teaching on homosexuality didn't come from prejudice but from God. (AP)



BRIEFLY

Yuvraj lone Indian to make cut in Spain; Shubhankar, Veer out



Yuvraj Sandhu, who is playing his maiden DP World Tour season, was the lone Indian to make the cut at the Estrella Damm Catalunya Championship leaderboard here. Sandhu, who shot 4-under 68 on the first day, carded even par on the second day. He was placed at T-16. However, India's other two golfers in the field Shubhankar Sharma (71-74) and Veer Ahlawat (75-72) missed the cut. Stefano Mazzoli and Lucas Bjerregaard head into the weekend tied at the top. Rookie Mazzoli, who secured promotion to the DP World Tour by a top eight finish on the 2025 Road to Mallorca Rankings, set the early target on Friday with a bogey free 67. Having opened with a 66, the Italian made a quick start to the second round with back-to-back birdies from the first and maintained the momentum. His third gain came on the fifth hole. Then came a remarkable run of 11 straight pars before a birdie-birdie finish. He almost chipped in for eagle at the last. Meanwhile, Bjerregaard matched Mazzoli with his own final hole birdie to cap off a second round 67. A shot behind the pair at the top is South African Yurav Premllall, who carded the lowest round of his DP World Tour career with an eight-under-par 64 to head into the weekend on ten-under.

Torino grabs glory with promotion to Serie A



Torino scored two headers in four minutes to come from behind and beat Sassuolo 2-1 in a mid-table clash in Serie A. Sassuolo took the lead through Norwegian midfielder Kristian Thorstvedt in the 51st minute but Giovanni Simeone equalized for Torino with a header midway through the second half and then another Norwegian, Marcus Pedersen, scored against his old team to give it the lead four minutes later on Friday. The result got Torino back to winning ways after last week's defeat at Udinese and means that loss is the only one in its last six matches. The win took it into 12th place, five points behind Sassuolo in 10th. Frosinone promoted to Serie A: Frosinone will play next season in Serie A after it beat Mantova 5-0 to guarantee second place and automatic promotion to the top tier along with Serie B champion Venezia, which secured its place last week. Monza, Palermo, Catanzaro, Modena, Juve Stabia, and Avellino will compete for the final promotion spot, while Reggiana, Pescara and Spezia were relegated to Serie C.

Gupta moves Sports Ministry over unpaid Odisha Open dues

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Renowned Indian Grandmaster Abhijeet Gupta has been left frustrated in his attempts to secure the prize money for the Odisha Open title he won earlier this year, with repeated assurances from the organisers yielding no result.

Despite writing several letters to the All India Chess Federation, the Chess Olympiad medallist is yet to receive the payment, forcing him to seek intervention from the Sports Ministry. Sources said the Odisha association is embroiled in infighting, with its bank account frozen, leaving the organisers unable

to clear the dues. "I kindly request the Ministry of Youth Affairs and Sports to look into this matter and help ensure that players receive their rightful prize money with transparency and accountability," wrote the 36-year-old Gupta, the first player to win the Commonwealth Chess Championship five times, on 'X'. "This is not just about one unpaid prize. It is about protecting the dignity and trust of every chess player in India." Gupta also told PTI that the organisers owe him ₹5.5 lakh in prize money for the tournament he won in January. "I won the Odisha Open in January 2026. The organisers assured me that



the prize money would be paid within a month. However, when I followed up later, they stopped responding," he said.

"As a sportsperson, you learn to accept losses more often than victories — that is

part of the journey. But what hurts even more is winning and still not receiving what you rightfully earned."

A source in the AICF said the organisers of the Odisha Open were unable to pay Gupta because their bank

account had been frozen amid infighting within the state association.

"There is infighting within the association, with rival factions locked in a dispute, because of which the account has been frozen and players are not getting their dues," the source said.

Gupta also wrote that he had tried reaching out to the AICF but received no response. "Since the tournament was affiliated with the All India Chess Federation, I also reached out to the federation's president and secretary, hoping the matter would be resolved fairly. Unfortunately, there has been no response from them either. "If this can happen to

someone honoured with the Arjuna Award, one can only imagine the struggles faced by players at the grassroots level of chess in India," added Gupta. A senior AICF official, however, said on condition of anonymity that the federation had "reached out" to Gupta. "I am 100 per cent certain that the issue will be resolved soon. The idea is to work for the players. Let us understand the issue (with Odisha association) and then we will resolve it," the official added. Gupta said he was forced to raise the issue on social media as nearly four months had passed since he won the title, but all he had received were repeated assurances.

Southampton charged for unauthorised filming in English spying row

STEVE DOUGLAS
■ Southampton

England's second-tier Championship has been hit with another spying controversy. Southampton was charged by the English Football League late Friday with a breach of its regulations after being accused of the unauthorised filming of Middlesbrough's practice sessions ahead of the teams' meeting in the Championship playoffs.

The matter will be referred, the EFL said in a statement, to an independent disciplinary commission which will be asked to undertake a hearing "at the earliest opportunity" given the nature of the issue and with the playoff matches



taking place so soon.

The first leg is on Saturday, at Middlesbrough's Riverside Stadium. The second leg is on Tuesday in Southampton. The

EFL said the charges against Southampton relate to regulations which require clubs "to act towards each other with the utmost good faith"

and prohibit a club from "observing, or attempting to observe, another club's training session within 72 hours of a scheduled match" between

Akshay Bhatia moves closer to Top-10 at Truist

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Charlotte (US)

Indian-American golfer Akshay Bhatia edged closer to a top-10 placement, while Rory McIlroy began his chase of the leaders with a fine second nine at the Truist Championship.

Bhatia added 1-under 71 following two late bogeys and was tied 12th. McIlroy (70-67) moved into tied fifth, as Korean Sungjae Im (64-69) climbed to the very top at 9-under and a one-shot lead over Tommy Fleetwood (67-67) and Hero Indian Open winner, Alex Fitzpatrick (67-68), was tied third alongside Justin Thomas (67-68), and showed he is relishing his PGA Tour membership.

Bhatia was progressing well at 3-under through 12



holes when he was hit by back-to-back bogeys on the 13th and the 14th and

dropped to 1-under.

Sudarshan Yellamaraju, the Indo-Canadian, added

69 to his first round 71 and is now T-24, up eight places.

Yellamaraju had four birdies and two bogeys, the second of which came on the 18th.

Indo-American Sahith Theegala (72-71) stayed at T-43. He started on the 10th and had an action-filled stretch with two birdies, an eagle and two bogeys for a 1-under 35. On the second nine, he birdied the seventh but closed with back-to-back bogeys. For Sungjae Im, the season has not gone well as he has battled through a wrist injury and has only one top-40 finish. This week could change that.

McIlroy (70-67), the World No. 2, showed his form on the back nine and picked five birdies before dropping a bogey on 18th but his 67 saw him get into top-10 at tied

eighth in his first start since winning his second Masters title last month.

At one point, McIlroy hit 14 straight greens in regulation. Tommy Fleetwood shot 67 for the second straight day and trailed Im by one shot. Justin Thomas was two back, along with Alex Fitzpatrick, the brother of Matt Fitzpatrick, who is way back in T-55 with 74-70.

Rickie Fowler moved up into the mix with the day's low round of 8-under 63, which included nine birdies and is now T-8.

Cameron Young (68-70), a two-time winner on the PGA TOUR this year, shot 70 and is five shots back.

Thomas won the PGA Championship at Quail Hollow in 2017 and said he is feeling good this week.

Super Rapid & Blitz: Gukesh on fifth spot at half-way stage in blitz

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Warsaw (Poland)

World Champion D Gukesh endured a shaky start to the blitz section but recovered ground with a commanding victory over Poland's Jan-Krzysztof Duda in the ninth round of the Super Rapid and Blitz.

After finishing the rapid section with nine points out of a possible 18, Gukesh collected four more points from the opening nine blitz rounds to take his tally to 13 out of 27 at the halfway stage of the blitz competition.

Hans Moke Niemann of the United States continued to lead the tables despite a very mediocre show on the first day of blitz. The



American moved to 16.5 points after scoring 3.5/9 and is now a half point ahead of

compatriot Wesley So. The third American Fabiano Caruana shares the third spot

with Slovenian Vladimir Fedoseev on 15 points apiece, while Gukesh comes in next two points behind.

French duo of Firouzja Alireza and Maxime Vachier-Lagrave share the sixth spot on 12.5 points alongside Duda, while the next World championship challenger Javokhir Sindarov of Uzbekistan is in ninth spot on 12 points. Polish Radoslaw Wojtaszak completed the ten-player lineup with 10 points in his bag.

Gukesh started the third day of the tournament with a couple of losses against Wojtaszek and Alireza and lost two more against Caruana and Sindarov. The latter pulled one back against Gukesh after losing in the

rapid game. The highlight for Gukesh was an impressive win over tournament leader Hans Niemann before the Indian rounded off the day with a commanding victory against Jan-Krzysztof Duda.

With nine more blitz rounds remaining, the tournament is headed for an exciting finish.

Results round 18 with points: D Gukesh (Ind, 13) beat Duda Jan-Krzysztof (Pol, 12.5); Fabiano Caruana (Usa, 15) drew with Vladimir Fedoseev (Slo, 15); Hans Moke Niemann (Usa, 16.5) lost to Radoslaw Wojtaszek (Pol, 10); Wesley So (Usa, 16) drew with Javokhir Sindarov (Uzb, 12); Maxime Vachier-Lagrave (Fra, 12.5) drew with Firouzja Alireza (Fra, 12.5).

Pukhraj Gill holds nerve to win maiden ADT title in Kuala Lumpur

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kuala Lumpur

Pukhraj Singh Gill, who held at least a share of the lead since the end of the first round, won the ADT Players Championship presented by The R&A, after a tense three-way play-off here.

A courageous Gill overcame a two-shot deficit over the last two holes and then finished off the job in extra holes at Saujana's Palm Course. Gill (72), who plays for the team, Honer Homes Gurugram, on the IGPL, totalled 13-under as did Thanawin Lee (68) and Sean Ramos (68).

It took Gill two extra holes to secure the title and a cheque of \$19,250 at the

Saujana Golf and Country Club. The win puts Gill in a good position to make a bid for ADT Order of Merit and next he will play at the AM Green IGPL Morocco Rising Stars event at the Mazagan Beach Golf Resort.

After four events on the schedule Gill is third on the Order of Merit. Another Indian, Kartik Singh, who played in the IGPL in 2025, shot the day's lowest round of 65 and finished T-30 and Khalin Joshi (77) was T-46.

Gill sealed his win with a six-foot putt in the second play-off hole. Even as the ball disappeared into the cup, he threw his hands up and let out a roar of relief. He was immediately besieged by his fellow Indian players includ-



ing Aman Raj and Aryan Roopa Anand, who were also playing this week.

Gill said, "It took a long time coming. This feels surreal. I think it's going to take a while to sink in, but I'm just so pumped right now. It's been a great week

in Malaysia. I was very happy with the course design, playing it for the first time — "It just really suits my eye, I am glad I could play the game I did."

Gill said it will take some for the victory to sink in. "I made it a lot more 'inter-

esting' than I would have liked to towards the end. It went into a play-off. And to have won after that I feel I am on Cloud 9. It is going to take some time to sink in.

"But it is only onwards and upwards from here, A big thank you to all the people back in India, I am so grateful for all your messages and support. I can't wait to get back to party and celebrate."

"I wish to thank IGPL for providing us a great Tour back home and to my team Honer Homes Gurugram for whom I play on the IGPL," he added. It was Gill's first international title, and it came within months of his maiden pro title on the 2025 IGPL Tour. Gill had a share of

the lead after the first round and was sole leader by two after two rounds and held a one-shot advantage after the third round.

Taking a one-shot lead over Ramos into the final round, Gill started hot with three birdies over his first four holes to extend his advantage to five shots.

However, dropped shots on the sixth and the ninth and some great play by Ramos and Lee saw his advantage cut back to one.

The tense affair continued into the final stretch. Lee took the lead with a four-foot birdie at the par-three 12th hole, while Gill responded with his own birdie at the par-five 13th after finding the green in two.

Katy Perry will perform at SoFi Stadium before first World Cup game



ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Coral Gables (US)

Katy Perry will perform at SoFi Stadium in Inglewood, California, on June 12 before the first World Cup game in the United States, as FIFA announced entertainment Friday night before the initial matches in all three nations that will host games in the expanded 48-nation tournament. Rappers Future, Lisa and Tyla, singer Anitta, singer/rapper Rema and DJ Sanjoy will be part of the ceremony before the US plays Paraguay.

Entertainment before the tournament opener between Mexico and South Africa at Mexico City's Azteca Stadium on June 11 will include Tyla and the groups Los Angeles Azules and Mana. Canada's opener against Bosnia and Herzegovina at Toronto's BMO Field will have entertainment by singers Alanis Morissette, Michael Buble, Alessia Cara, Jessie Reyez, Nora Fatehi, William Prince, Elyanna and Vegedream, along with DJ Sanjoy.

Wrestling Federation issues showcause notice to Phogat

AMANPREET SINGH ■ New Delhi

The Wrestling Federation of India (WFI) on Saturday issued a detailed show-cause notice to Vinesh Phogat, accusing her of indiscipline and anti-doping rule violations, and declared her ineligible to compete in domestic events till June 26, 2026 for failing to complete the mandatory six-month notice period required for athletes returning from retirement under UWW Anti-Doping Rules.

It means that the two-time World Championship medallist will have to wait for her comeback as she was tragetting the National Open Ranking event in Gonda, starting Sunday, for her return to competition after quitting the sport in 2024 following her disqualification from the Paris Olympic Games. In the 15-page notice, the WFI alleged that Vinesh's conduct had caused

"lasting damage to reputation of Indian wrestling" in Paris and violated provisions of the WFI Constitution, UWW International Wrestling Rules and anti-doping regulations.

Allegations have flown thick and fast in the last few days. Vinesh had accused WFI of blocking her entry for the Gonda event and also said that she was one of the six complainants against former WFI chief Brij Bhushan Sharan Singh, who has been accused of sexual harassment.

WFI said that compliance with WADA rules was non-negotiable and the onus to prove her eligibility was on Vinesh.

"We have to see if WADA rules have been followed properly. It has not yet been proved that she has fulfilled the requirements for coming back from retirement. She has to complete the mandatory six-month notice period



before she becomes eligible to compete again," WFI President Sanjay Singh said. **Broad Charges:** The federation has sought her explanation on several charges, including her disqualification from the

2024 Paris Games after failing to make weight, alleged whereabouts failures under anti-doping rules, and competing in two weight categories during the March 2024 selection trials conducted by

the then IOA-appointed ad-hoc panel.

The federation specifically mentioned that she is not eligible to compete in any domestic event till June 26 this year, including the National Open Ranking Tournament in Gonda.

"The Federation must satisfy itself that you have not committed an Anti-Doping Rule Violation that would render you ineligible to represent the Federation in any forthcoming competition," the notice stated. The notice also referred to a May 4, 2026 communication from the International Testing Agency (ITA), acting on behalf of UWW, recording a "missed Test" against Vinesh in relation to an unsuccessful dope-control attempt on December 18, 2025.

Referring to Article 5.7 of the UWW Anti-Doping Rules dealing with return from retirement, the WFI stated that Vinesh remains ineligible to compete till

June 26, 2026 and therefore cannot participate in any domestic event before that date.

The federation specifically mentioned that she is not eligible to compete in the Senior Open Ranking Tournament at Nandini Nagar, Gonda, scheduled from May 10 to 12.

The federation mentioned that as per world governing body UWW's rules, any athlete seeking to return to competition from retirement must notify UWW at least six months in advance while remaining available for testing during that period, and she has not fulfilled the condition.

The WFI alleged that Vinesh, in a December 14, 2024 e-mail to UWW Anti-Doping, had declared herself to be on a "sabbatical until August 2025" and indicated that she would resume compliance with whereabouts obligations only thereafter. (PTI)

Gill 84, Rashid 4/33 help Gujarat thrash Rajasthan by 77 runs

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Jaipur

Leg-spinner Rashid Khan returned to his magical best with a four-wicket haul after his skipper Shubman Gill struck a sublime 84 as Gujarat Titans outclassed Rajasthan Royals by 77 runs to move a step closer to the IPL playoffs, here on Saturday.

Gill and Sai Sudharsan (55) stitched a commanding 118-run opening stand as Gujarat Titans piled up their season-best 229 for 4 after Rajasthan Royals opted to bowl on a batting-friendly deck.

In reply, Rajasthan began in explosive fashion through teenage sensation Vaibhav Sooryavanshi, who smashed 36 off just 16 balls with the help of three fours and three sixes, while Dhruv Jurel kept up the momentum with a rapid 24 off 10

deliveries (1x4, 3x6).

At 62/2 in five overs, Rajasthan looked firmly in the chase before Gujarat's bowlers turned the game around to bowl the home side out for 152 in 16.3 overs.

The victory was Gujarat Titans' fourth on the trot as they joined table-toppers Sunrisers Hyderabad on 14 points and tightened their grip on a playoff spot.

The pace duo of Kagiso Rabada (2/33 from 3 overs) and Mohammed Siraj (1/55) struck early blows in the powerplay before Rashid took complete control through the middle overs with a match-winning spell of 4/33. Bowling between the eighth and 14th overs, Rashid exploited the slight turn on offer brilliantly and broke the backbone of Rajasthan's chase.

He removed Jurel and Donovan Ferreira in the space of three balls.



Gujarat Titans' captain Shubman Gill plays a shot during an Indian Premier League (IPL) 2026 T20 cricket match between Rajasthan Royals and Gujarat Titans in Jaipur, Rajasthan on Saturday

PTI

He first knocked back Jurel's off stump with a teasing length delivery before rattling Ferreira with a sharp leg-break that drifted in and turned away.

He later trapped Ravindra Jadeja lbw and finished with four wickets, including three bowled dismissals, as Rajasthan kept losing wickets at regular intervals and handed the biggest win to GT.

Jason Holder wrapped up the tail returning with figures of 3/12 in his 2.3 overs. Sooryavanshi gave Rajasthan a flying start by smashing the very first ball of the innings for six. He then took on Rabada with back-to-back sixes as the Royals raced to 26 without loss in two overs.

Siraj too came under attack, conceding three boundaries in four balls to the fearless youngster. But the India pacer eventually had the last laugh with a well-directed

short ball that forced a mistimed pull, ending Sooryavanshi's entertaining cameo.

Rabada then struck another big blow in the following over, dismissing Yashasvi Jaiswal, who led RR on Saturday after regular captain Riyan Parag pulled his hamstring in the previous match, with a 152kph bouncer that was miscued to extra cover.

Jurel briefly revived Rajasthan's hopes by smashing Siraj for three sixes and a four in a 22-run over, but Gujarat wrested back control once Rashid entered the attack.

Put in to bat, Gill's 44-ball knock, studded with nine fours and three sixes, was a masterclass in timing and strokeplay as he mixed elegance with aggression despite struggling briefly with discomfort in his left foot before reaching his fourth IPL fifty this season.

Yashasvi, Shafali get NADA notices for missed dope tests

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Indian cricketers Yashasvi Jaiswal and Shafali Verma have been issued notices by the National Anti-Doping Agency (NADA) for not being available for scheduled dope tests last year, leading to their first whereabouts failure.

It is reliably learnt that the two players, who are a part of the NADA's Registered Testing Pool (RTP), did not explain the reasons for the missed tests, leading to the notices.

"Notices have been issued to the concerned athletes, and the same has been intimated to the national federation (the BCCI) and the ICC," a well-placed source said even



though NADA declined comment citing confidentiality of the procedure.

On being contacted, a BCCI source also confirmed the development.

"Yes, we have received notification from NADA on missed tests. We will check with them as to how it happened, and will take necessary steps so that such things

do not happen in future.

"Cricket is back in the Olympics and we need to adhere to all the protocols so that everything goes on smoothly," the BCCI source said, referring to cricket's inclusion in the 2028 Los Angeles Olympic Games roster.

Yashasvi is currently playing in the IPL for

Rajasthan Royals, while Shafali was part of the Indian women's team that recently toured South Africa for a white-ball series.

Athletes in the RTP are required to share their whereabouts with the anti-doping agency and be available for testing in a specified window everyday.

Three missed tests are considered a doping violation and can lead to suspensions. Currently, 13 cricketers are part of NADA's RTP for the ongoing quarter. The list features 348 athletes in all.

India's T20 World Cup-winning stars Abhishek Sharma and Axar Patel were the most noticeable recent additions to the pool, which is dominated by athletics.

Suryansh Shedge credits Ponting, Shreyas Iyer for mindset shift

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Punjab Kings all-rounder Suryansh Shedge on Saturday credited head coach Ricky Ponting and skipper Shreyas Iyer for helping him undergo a crucial mindset shift that has played a key role in his strong performance in the ongoing Indian Premier League season.

The Mumbai all-rounder said regular conversations with Iyer and Ponting have helped him focus on preparation, staying in the present, and trusting his instincts — lessons that have enabled him to make the most of opportunities once he broke into the playing XI.



"Shreyas bhai told me during an internal match before the IPL that I was batting well and not to over-think. If I had thought about things not in my control, I wouldn't have been able to perform in that situation," Shedge said during a round table on Saturday.

"He talks a lot about technique and attitude." On Ponting's influence, Shedge said the Australian great has constantly stressed the importance of preparation. "Ricky sir has been all about preparation and preparation. He says whatever happens, be courageous, back yourself and know that you belong," he said.

Jadhav wins maiden World Cup medal with bronze in Shanghai

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Shanghai

Reigning World University Games champion Sahil Jadhav clinched his maiden Archery World Cup medal in only his second appearance on the global circuit, winning a bronze in the compound men's event of the Stage 2, here on Saturday.

The 25-year-old Maharashtra veteran defeated Denmark veteran player-cum-coach Martin Damsbo 147-144 in the bronze medal playoff to secure India's first medal of the ongoing tournament.

It also marked India's final medal in the com-



ound section after none of his fellow mates reached the medal rounds.

India, traditionally a powerhouse in compound team events, had endured a disappointing campaign as all

their teams bowed out early. India will now look to add two more medals on the concluding day on Sunday in the recurve section.

The women's team will compete for gold, while Simranjeet Kaur will begin her campaign from the semifinals, needing one win to secure her maiden World Cup medal.

Jadhav was trailing by one point after the opening end as the 40-year-old Damsbo started with three perfect 10s. But the Indian responded strongly in the second end, shooting a perfect 30 while the Dane managed 27, helping Jadhav move ahead 59-57 overall.

Reels in restricted zones, late night outings led to BCCI's IPL crackdown

G UNNIKRISHNAN ■ Begaluru

Reels made in restricted areas, outings that did not have security approvals and players' proximity to social media influencers were some of the concerns that prompted the stern advisory from BCCI and IPL franchises are now scrambling to ensure compliance without compromising on individual privacy.

The Board's Anti-Corruption Unit flagged unauthorised guests in the hotel rooms of players, support staff and team officials and also warned of potential honey traps. As a result, the BCCI came up with an advisory that placed restrictions on the guests and made it mandatory for the players to keep security informed about

their movements.

One of the major violations pointed out was the players' "excessive proximity" to influencers, who get hired for short durations to create social media content for the participating teams.

In one such incident, one of the younger players asked the newcomers in the content team to assist him with reels, videos and pictures to be used on his private social media accounts.

While it's not an uncommon practice for a player to take external help for neo-media content generation, in this particular instance, the vlogger used some of the videos and pictures on his own private account to gain traction.

The shoot happened



inside the boundary line with clear visuals of the team's training and other on-field activities. It later spilled over to the player's hotel room as well.

The BCCI was not amused. "Yes, we have received a

new set of rules from the BCCI and steps are being taken to follow them with diligence. The new crop of players are so much into this social media activity. Yes, it is a modern trend, we accept it. But it has to be done within

the limit set by the BCCI," a franchise official said.

"...it's impossible to track each and every movement of people. It's an issue. What we are trying to do is to make the players and content teams more aware of the BCCI

norms, and the consequences if they break them."

A step in that direction is cutting down the size of content teams.

"We are trying to limit the number of content team members, particularly those who get hired for a fixed term like 2-3 months during an IPL season.

"Senior players will know the rules and how to follow them. But at times, cricketers coming to the IPL for the first time might not know the gravity of the situation. They will be eager to emulate the stars and get some social media likes and comments. So, we need to educate them more," the official added.

The intruders: As for unauthorised visitors in players' and support staff's rooms, the

Board's concerns deepened after another player was recently found hosting a few people in his room well into the night quite often.

The BCCI ACU officer immediately summoned the team manager to enquire about the meetings, but the reply was "casual and disinterested".

The manager cited the player's seniority in the team's ranks to defend him. "I am not surprised. At times, the players use their stature within the team to bend the rules. Once I told a player to host his friends in the lobby restaurant, not in his room.

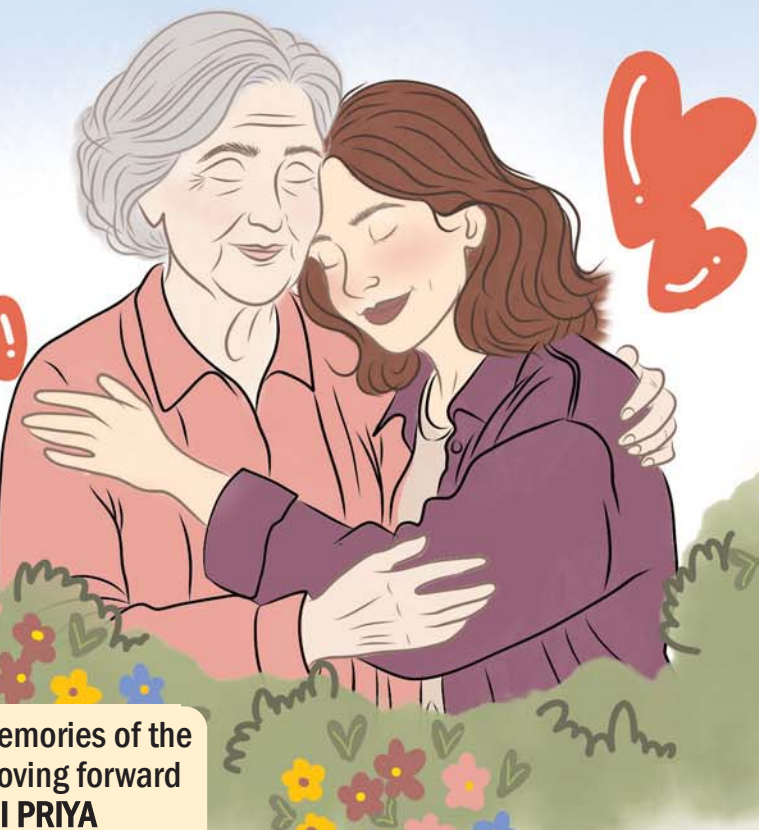
"I told him there are some board instructions on such matters. He just snapped: 'You don't worry. I will tell the

board (officials), if they ask,'" said a former official, who worked for a long time in the IPL as team manager.

Another franchise official offered his view on this. "Well, I don't know about such arm-twisting (by players). But we have now given out clear instructions that a written or at least verbal permission is required to invite friends and family to the hotel where the team stays.

"I know they also need to meet family and friends. But we have told them not to entertain guests after 10 pm, and such meetings should happen in the lobby or any other public place where the team manager/officials should have ready access," the official stated. (PTI)

She remembers everything



How many versions of our past selves exist entirely within the memories of the women who raised us? We spend our adult lives aggressively moving forward and discarding earlier versions curator of all those, says SAKSHI PRIYA

How many of our forgotten selves do we simply leave behind in the dark? As adults we ruthlessly march forward and drop our past identities by the wayside without a single backwards glance. We shed the frightened child, the terrified teenager, and the hesitant youth, leaving those heavy layers of old pain far behind us in our absolute rush to grow up.

Yet exactly one person acts as the silent curator of all those forgotten identities. A mother operates as the living repository of a human being's entire history. A mother stands as the solitary witness to the unsaid fears of our beginnings. She remembers the exact pitch of a midnight terror and the heavy, frightened weight of a child pressing against her collarbone, long after that child has completely forgotten those ancient nights of panic. She holds the complete map of your physical and emotional scars.

Society consistently forces the concept of motherhood into comfortable pastels and soft lighting. We receive a highly sanitised script of gentle sacrifices and endless patience. This collective delusion

completely ignores the fierce psychological endurance the role actually requires from a woman. To mother someone is to stand constantly between a fragile life and an unpredictable universe. She absorbs the heavy shocks of the outside world and meticulously filters the chaos to present her child with a safe reality. Every seemingly mundane act of pouring breakfast cereal or folding school uniforms rests heavily upon an exhausting daily effort to keep the world's inherent cruelty firmly outside the front door. We rarely speak aloud about the fundamental tragedy built into the very design of this intimate relationship. The absolute success of a mother relies entirely upon her ability to render herself obsolete. She spends decades pouring every single ounce of her physical energy, her intellect, and her sanity into building a fiercely independent individual.

She does this fully aware that the ultimate reward for her flawless craftsmanship is watching them walk away. She spends her life teaching her child exactly how to leave her behind. This specific brand of devotion requires a level of quiet devastation and

supreme grace that our commercial holidays utterly fail to capture.

We must particularly recognise the women who carry this heavy weight entirely alone. So many women act as both the shield and the sword within their homes, raising children single handedly or carrying the entire emotional load within a crowded family space. They navigate the silent terror of solitary parenting with an unmatched, stoic brilliance.

Yet we must completely rewrite the old story that insists a mother must bury her own life to grow another. Raising a child is never a permanent surrender. The private ambitions you packed away in the dark while you kept your family safe are still sitting exactly where you left them. The geometry of the hole left behind when you stepped away from your own path can still be filled with your own brilliant work. The road is completely clear for you to move forward right now. You still hold the fire to chase down whatever you want, and you must do it entirely for your own joy without a shred of guilt. To the women navigating the quiet terrors of raising children alone, to

the silent keepers of our oldest fears, and to every mother finally walking toward her own delayed future, we see your fierce, unbroken power. Your next chapter belongs entirely to you. *Happy Mother's Day.*

WHAT DO YOU DO FOR YOUR MOTHER?

Shop-bought gifts are easy. Making your mum feel truly seen is harder and more worth it. Here's where our team would start.

●Cook Her Favourite Meal:

She spent years feeding you. Now cook for her. That dish she always made – set the table, light a candle, and let her be looked after for once

●Write Her a Letter:

Not a text. A proper handwritten letter. Thank her for everything she quietly did and the faith she always had in you. She will keep it forever.

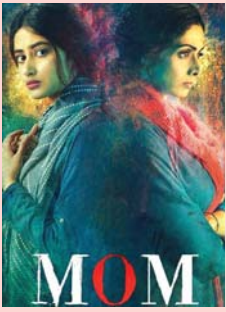
●Give Her a Whole Day of You:

Phone away, just the two of you. A walk, a cup of tea, old photographs, whatever she fancies. Nothing beats a whole day of your time.

WHAT TO WATCH?



MRS CHATTERJEE VS NORWAY
The movie serves as a poignant, albeit intense, tribute to the lengths a mother will go to protect her children.



MOM
Sridevi's performance in Mom shatters the submissive caregiver image, reimagining maternal love as a strike against injustice that values survival over moral codes.



HELICOPTER EELA
Kajol's Helicopter Eela challenges the 'smother-mother' trope, showing that a woman's ambitions can coexist with maternal devotion.



NIL BATTEY SANNATA
Chanda's classroom journey in Nil Battey Sannata dismantles the 'helpless martyr' stereotype, proving that a mother's fiercest gift is the shared audacity to pick up a pen and dream bigger.

Naseeruddin Shah gives voice to forests of the Northeast

The room of conversation, culture, and hills resonated with indigenous melodies. Hosted by the Government of Meghalaya, this New Delhi Prelude served as a cultural bridge to November's *Shillong Literary Festival*, with live grassroots music honoring unspoken regional histories.

Listeners, including Navees with Insha, gathered. Discussions gave space to the unsaid stories of displaced communities. Chief Minister Conrad K Sangma and Shekhar Gupta discussed building a year-round creative economy, while Sangma and Union Minister Jyotiraditya Scindia took in the Living Root Bridges display. On the cinema front, filmmakers Dominic Sangma and Pradip Kurbah called the 'Hello Meghalaya' platform a much-needed lifeline for independent storytellers. Grounding these discussions, Streamlet Dkhar and Crystal Cornelious D Marak delivered readings of Khasi and Garo classics, preserving linguistic history.

Then Naseeruddin Shah took over. He opened with James Thurber's fables, laying bare the ugly reality of human greed against nature. He then shifted to Vikram Seth's *Beastly Tales from Here and There*, reading about the pristine Bingle Valley. His voice brought the land of scarlet rhododendrons and cold rivers into immediate focus. He then shifted to Vikram Seth's work, reading about pristine Bingle Valley. His voice brought the land of scarlet rhododendrons and cold rivers into immediate focus. He narrated the tale of the elephant and the trapezoid drinking lukewarm tea.

The attendees sat in absolute silence as the creatures discussed disturbing human schemes to cut down the woods. By giving voice to these forest dwellers, Shah highlighted the deep, raw pain of those facing the sudden loss of their home. His commanding reading united literature, music, and art, bringing the quiet fears of the hills directly into the center of the capital.



PHOTOS: PANKAJ KUMAR

ARTISTS FROM THE GRASSROOTS MUSIC PROGRAM TOOK OVER THE STAGE AND BROUGHT THE WHOLE EVENING ALIVE WITH MEGHALAYA'S MUSIC AND CULTURE



Gracie Abrams in Chanel: Klimt's 'Woman in Gold' reimagined in decadent mosaic.

Cardi B as Hans Bellmer's The Doll (1936): Surrealism in motion.

The art of dress

A look at how the 2026 Met Gala turned history into a vibrant moving gallery, writes SAKSHI PRIYA

Where exactly does a canvas end and a breathing body begin? The Metropolitan Museum uses its massive annual charity fundraiser to erase the line between gallery and street. The 2026 Met Gala's Costume Art theme dared guest to turn oil paints and stone into wearable fabric. Art stands as highest form of expression. If fashion wants to step into that visual world it must be entirely experiential.

The famed steps became a moving gallery. Cardi B weaponised her shape by turning the fragmented dolls of Hans Bellmer into a fever dream. Gracie Abrams wore the golden armour of Klimt. Rachel Zegler carried vulnerability of Lady Jane Grey in white. The Slipped strap of Sargent's Madame X found separate reincarnations through Claire Foy, Lauren Sánchez Bezos and Julianne Moore. Rebellious painted detail survives for centuries. Amy Sherard brought her graphic palette into space. Kim Kardashian encased flesh in industrial shell of Allen Jones. Seeing the natural body locked inside sculpture feels unsettling. Naomi Watts turned couture into blooms of Dutch still life. Alexa Chung distilled Monet lily while Lisa Airan danced flawlessly in Matisse colours. Madonna commanded dream-

scape from Leonora Carrington. Kendall Jenner and Yu-Chi Lyra Kuo channelled the wet draped stone of ancient Winged Victory of Samothrace. Ben Platt brought dots of Seurat while Miles Chamley-Watson mirrored chaos of Cubism. Heidi Klum committed to marble illusion of The Veiled Virgin. Audrey Nuna wore crystals mimicking Pollock splatters. Rosé modernised Braque while Alexa Ashe Meyers became brushstroke of Yves Klein blue and Angela Bassett carried poise of Laura Wheeler Waring.

Raja Ravi Varma caught tension in Padmini The Lotus Lady. He took weight of myths and painted them with soft realism. Taking beauty off flat canvas into garment takes visionary skill. Isha Ambani achieved this cultural homage in custom Gaurav Gupta sari. Structural draping mirrored heavy folds of royal portraiture while delicate embellishments reflected soft luminosity of lotus itself. When art wraps around living breathing body it stops being clothes. It becomes shared pulse between past and present proving that greatest masterpieces belong out in the bold chaotic world moving alongside us instead of hanging silently on a cold museum wall.

THE LOTUS REALISM

A painting is meant to stay perfectly still but the best ones always look like they are about to step towards you. Raja Ravi Varma caught that exact tension in Padmini The Lotus Lady. He took the heavy weight of our ancient myths and painted them with a shockingly soft realism.

Witnesses to the unsaid



Dakhin | Dilli brings together devotional art and sacred artefacts from across North and South India, each piece steeped in tradition and meaning

TEAM VIVA

At Bikaner House, Raseel Gujral Ansal mounts a collection that demands close observation. Hosted at Arzaani Atelier Privé, 'Dakhin | Dilli: A Sacred Dialogue' pulls regional artistic traditions into one room, forcing a strict visual confrontation between the Deccan and the North.

The artifacts carry the heavy, physical weight of belief. The *Kamdhenu* Tanjore sculpture, heavy with 24-carat gold leaf, owns the room the moment you walk in. Close by, the whole feeling changes. Mysore reverse glass paintings, such as *Yashoha* and *Krishna*, offer a fragile, precise clarity, while the *Vintage Khejri* Pichwai maps out sprawling

pastoral scenes on cloth. Before arriving in this gallery, every object here, right down to the towering, polychrome wood of the *Hanuman Vahanam*, served a functional role in centuries-old rituals, holding the unspoken fears and quiet pains of the people who prayed to them.

Raseel Gujral Ansal notes that this curation explores a visual language where Southern intricacies meet Northern lyrical detailing. She views the sacred as a living aesthetic that defines identity. By placing Raja Ravi Varma's accessible oleographs next to contemporary pieces, she bridges the gap between ancient ritual and modern life. This shows that devotion remains a constant, breathing force today.

The exhibition entirely sidesteps standard gallery gloss. It presents these historical works as surviving witnesses to the unsaid, standing firm as raw records of complex faith.



PHOTOS: PANKAJ KUMAR



Angela Bassett in Prabal Gurung: The elegant spirit of Laura Wheeler Waring's *Girl in Pink Dress* (1927).



The Pioneer

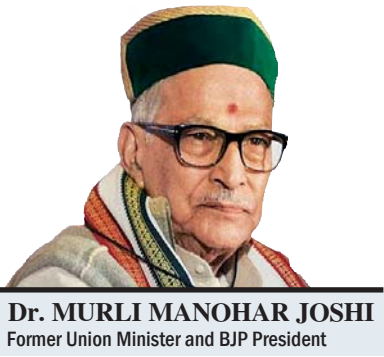
AGENDA

Democracy... is a charming form of government, full of variety and disorder, and dispensing a sort of equality to equals and unequals alike
— Plato



I would like to recall that during a debate in the Lok Sabha, Pt. Nehru pointed towards Dr Mookerjee and declared, “Jana Sangh is a communal party. I will crush the Jana Sangh.” To this, Dr Mookerjee got up and promptly replied to Nehru’s remarks, amid applause, “My friend Pandit Jawaharlal Nehru says that he will crush Jana Sangh. I say, I will crush this crushing mentality.”

LOTUS BLOOMS IN BENGAL, VIJAY WHISTLES IN TAMIL NADU



Dr. MURLI MANOHAR JOSHI
Former Union Minister and BJP President

I would like to heap a lot of praise on the formation of the first-ever BJP Government in West Bengal after posting a historic win in the Assembly elections. The seed planted by the founder of the Bharatiya Jana Sangh, Dr Syama Prasad Mookerjee, has now become a full-grown lotus.

It is a matter of immense pride that the land of Dr Mookerjee has given a rousing mandate to the BJP after decades of struggle and the sacrifices of hundreds of party workers. I applaud the current leadership — Prime Minister Narendra Modi, BJP president Nitin Nabin and Home Minister Amit Shah — for rewriting history in West Bengal.

It is a great day for the BJP and crores of its workers, and I would like to extend my good wishes to the newly appointed Chief Minister, Suwendu Adhikari. It is another great moment to recall Dr Mookerjee's relationship with another Bengal icon, Rabindranath Tagore. Notably, during his tenure as Vice-Chancellor of University of Calcutta, Dr Syama Prasad Mookerjee invited Tagore to deliver the university's convocation address in Bengali for the first time in 1937, a significant cultural milestone.

The BJP has grown over the years despite being suppressed by the governments of the day. We fought Congress and Left rule in West Bengal. Our fight with Congress began way back in 1951 when Dr Syama Prasad Mookerjee formed the Jana Sangh (the precursor to the BJP, formed on 21 October 1951), and was one of its three elected MPs in 1952 during India's first General Elections. At that point, caste was not a predominant factor in voting patterns; instead, voting was based largely on ideological divisions such as socialist, Leftist and Jana

Sangh ideologies.

Pandit Jawaharlal Nehru, as Prime Minister and Congress leader, viewed the fledgling Jana Sangh as a communal party linked to RSS ideology and saw it as a threat to his vision of secularism and Congress dominance. This was a time when any kind of political dissent used to be crushed. Nonetheless, it is Congress that must be blamed for developing the tactics of decimating the Opposition and drifting away from the basic principles of democracy.

I would like to recall that during a debate in the Lok Sabha, Pt Nehru pointed towards Dr Mookerjee and declared, “Jana Sangh is a communal party. I will crush the Jana Sangh.” To this, Dr Mookerjee got up and promptly replied to Nehru's remarks, amid applause, “My friend Pandit Jawaharlal Nehru says that he will crush Jana Sangh. I say, I will crush this crushing mentality.”

Dr Mookerjee's sharp rejoinder bordered on the core idea of defiantly rejecting Nehru's “crushing” threat and framing it as authoritarian overreach. It may be recalled that the exchange was widely remembered and later cited by Atal Bihari Vajpayee, one of the towering figures of post-independent India.

The parliamentary exchange reflected hostility towards the Jana Sangh, and Dr Mookerjee used the floor to attack Nehru's policies on Kashmir, foreign affairs and national unity, while Nehru tried to portray the Jana Sangh as a fringe threat.

I witnessed the first Lok Sabha elections held in 1952. Since then, a lot has changed. Political parties now depend on technology. In 1952, slips carrying the names of candidates were given to voters, who were supposed to place them in the respective ballot boxes. There was no concept of reserved seats then, but different candidates could contest from the same seat. For instance, from Phulpur constituency, Pt Nehru contested as a general candidate while Masuriyadeen contested as a minority candidate. Things have changed now.

Coming back to the BJP's landslide win in West Bengal, I would mention that during my tenure as BJP president, I extensively toured the State to strengthen the party. We held the National Executive meeting in Calcutta in April



জলদ্বারে একতা যাত্রায় ডঃ নেহরুকে ত্বরবাহী দিয়ে স্বাগত জানানো হয়। পাশে দাঁড়িয়ে স্বগভীর ডঃ বলদেব প্রসাদ।

BENGAL

Party Name	Seats Won
Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP)	207
All India Trinamool Congress (AITC)	80
Indian National Congress (INC)	2
Aam Janata Unnayan Party (AJUP)	2
Communist Party of India (Marxist)	1
All India Secular Front (AISF)	1
Total Seats Declared	293

1993. West Bengal has always remained a focus of the BJP leadership.

The political scenario has undergone a qualitative change during this period. The BJP has emerged as a dominant pole in Indian politics, and our adversaries are unable to digest our growth.

It was very satisfying to see a BJP Chief Minister being sworn in West Bengal. This is the culmination of Dr Mookerjee's dream and the hard work put in by our party workers. The current leadership has left no stone unturned in ensuring that the BJP scripts history in Kolkata.

Further talking about the dynamism of southern Indian politics, where the BJP is failing to breach Tamil Nadu's Dravidian fortress, I would state that Tamil Nadu remains one of the major State where the BJP has been unable to convert national momentum into electoral gains. Language is one issue that has been used by Dravidian parties to create north-south friction. The BJP's struggles in Tamil Nadu reflect its inability to increase its footprint in the State. The reasons are structural, not tactical.

A key factor is cultural compatibility.

Tamil religiosity, characterised by anti-Brahminical and non-Sanskritic traditions, especially the Bhakti and Self-Respect movements, stands apart from the practices favoured by the BJP. These traditions emphasise devotion while rejecting priestly rituals and the Varna hierarchy.

For example, C Rajagopalachari, despite being India's first Governor-General and a celebrated leader, was asked to step down as Chief Minister of Madras State because he was a Brahmin. This reflected the deep anti-Brahmin sentiment that shaped Tamil Nadu's political landscape.

Tamil Nadu has the maximum number of temples, and people are deeply religious, yet the BJP has not been able to gain a foothold in the State. Tamil film megastars MG Ramachandran and J Jayalalithaa shrewdly occupied the soft Hindutva space and inculcated devotion without Brahminical overtones, thus neutralising the BJP's only natural plank inside a Dravidian framework.

While Rajaji was forced to resign for being a Brahmin, Jayalalithaa, a Brahmin woman hailing from Karnataka, ruled Tamil Nadu for years. Tamils are emotional people, and they are not influenced by the rest of India's political set-up. They believe in hero worship rather than cult politics, and this needs to be studied. Actor Joseph Vijay's rise is the latest phenomenon in Tamil Nadu politics, and it will continue.

(As told to Deepak Kumar Jha, Executive Editor, and Pramod Kumar Singh, Resident Editor, The Pioneer)



ডাঃ নেহরু প্রস্তাবের বিরুদ্ধে আয়োজিত সভায় বাঁ দিক থেকে রাজমাতা বিজয়া রাজে সিক্কিয়া, সবশ্রী লাল কৃষ্ণ আদবানী অটল বিহারী বাজপেয়ী, ডঃ যোশী, মদন লাল খুরানা, কল্যান সিং ও অন্যান্য নেতৃবৃন্দ।

...shock and awe of 2026 polls...

KERALAM: A GAME OF MUSICAL CHAIRS

Keralam maintained its tradition of alternating power between major coalitions, as the Congress-led United Democratic Front (UDF) unseated the Left Democratic Front (LDF).

SEAT COUNT: Elections were held for 140 seats.

KEY DRIVERS: Analysts attributed the UDF win to successful campaigning by Rahul and Priyanka Gandhi, which helped overcome internal party factionalism.

BJP PRESENCE: The BJP made minor inroads but secured only three seats in the State Assembly.

ASSAM: BJP EXTENDS DOMINANCE

The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) secured a historic third consecutive term in the northeastern state.

LANDSLIDE VICTORY: The BJP-led coalition won 102 out of 126 seats, a significant increase from their 2021 tally of 75.

LEADERSHIP: Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma won his seat in Jalukbari and is set for a second term.

OPPOSITION: The Congress Party, despite a campaign led by Gaurav Gogoi, was reduced to just 19 seats.

PUDUCHERRY: NDA HOLDS FORT

The Union Territory saw the National Democratic Alliance (NDA) return to govern for a second consecutive term.

COALITION SUCCESS: The alliance led by the All India N.R. Congress (AINRC), featuring Chief Minister N. Rangaswamy, won a comfortable margin over the Congress-led INDIA bloc.

NEW DIMENSIONS: The election marked the entry of actor Vijay's party, Tamilara Vettai Kazhagam (TVK), which added a new competitive layer to the local political landscape.

TAMIL NADU

Party Name	Seats Won
Tamilara Vettai Kazhagam (TVK)	108
DMK	59
AIADMK	47
Indian National Congress	5
Pattali Makkal Katchi (PMK)	4
Communist Party of India (CPI)	2
Communist Party of India (Marxist)	2
Viduthala Chiruthaigal Katchi (VCK)	2
Indian Union Muslim League (IUML)	2
Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP)	1
Desiya Murpokku Dravida Kazhagam (DMDK)	1
Amma Makkal Munnettra Kazagam (AMMK)	1
Total	234

Thalapathy storms the citadel, interval for Dravidian dominance

South Indian fixation with cinematic actors as successful politicians has got yet another name ie, Chandrasekaran Joseph Vijay, or simply, Thalapathy (Commander) Vijay. Historically and culturally, movies have been a powerful medium to spread societal and political messages of justice, ethnic/regional pride, and anti-caste messaging that have stirred public imagination. Actors who played the screen protagonists became the face of those ideas and afforded themselves public reverence as veritable messiahs.

This phenomenon is particularly visible in Tamil and Telugu films with the likes of MG Ramachandran, Jayalalithaa, Karunanidhi, Vijayakant etc., to the likes of NT Rama Rao, Chiranjeevi, Pawan Kalyan etc., in the so-called Tollywood. Even Karnataka (euphemistically called Sandalwood) has had Rajkumar, Ambareesh, Upendra etc., while Kerala (Mollywood) has had Innocent Vareed Thekkethala, Suresh Gopi etc.

Almost everywhere, the actor-turned-

politician template saw the screen actors as real-time manifestations of their heroic roles (often mythological or in the David-versus-Goliath frame) to build trust, resonance, and preference in the electoral hustings. The screen imagery afforded a larger-than-life or Robin Hood-esque image as the valiant protector against injustice, discrimination, or corruption, who stood up valiantly for the poor.

This leads to a naturally blurred transition and perception of “goodness” from reel-to-reel for those seeking to make the shift from movies to the state assemblies, as their public persona is a political goldmine to tap.

That many of these actor-turned-politicians have acquitted themselves to be as good as non-actors (sometimes even better) has opened the doors for the likes of Thalapathy Vijay.



BHOPINDER SINGH
Former Lt Governor of Andaman & Nicobar Islands and Puducherry and a military veteran

active social work eg, arranging marriages, blood drives, relief work etc, to build personal brand and emotional attachment.

Vijay has followed the well-beaten track of addressing socio-political tensions through storytelling and loaded dialogues. The tell-tale trajectory saw him play the mandatory “angry young man”, albeit with idealistic moorings in Thamizhan and the Godfather-like Thalaivaava where he spouts his prophetic “time to lead” line. Later, as

The sensitive Dravidian realm has used films to carry political ideas and themes. It became imperative to embed scripts with lingering social messages that shaped public opinion. The accompanying phenomenon of “Fan Clubs” (Thalapathy Vijay had launched his Vijay Makkal Iyakkam in 2009) further lionised impressions of “hero as saviours” in a highly organised way with

the crusader focused on farmer suicide and corporate greed in Kaththi, the anti-GST proponent in Mersal, to Sarkar where he addresses voter fraud. In hindsight, the selection of scripts with their underlying themes was unmistakable in the route that he was charting all along. The carefully curated journey ensured that he could be perceived above caste or religious considerations, which otherwise play a major role in political preferences. Having vanquished the unimaginable duopoly of the Dravidian biggies ie, DMK and AIADMK (besides spurning overtures from national parties), Thalapathy Vijay has finally breached Fort St George in Chennai.

While Vijay has tiptoed his way very carefully without offending any section of Tamil society e.g., he named the entire galaxy of former Tamil politicians as his inspiration like KG Ramachandran, Karunanidhi, Periyar, Annadurai to Jayalalithaa — there is really nothing new in his manifesto that differentiates him from the other Dravidian politicians.

CONTINUED ON >> PII

“WAR: A MASSACRE OF PEOPLE WHO DON'T KNOW EACH OTHER FOR THE PROFIT OF PEOPLE WHO KNOW EACH OTHER BUT DON'T MASSACRE EACH OTHER”
— PAUL VALERY

Russia celebrates Victory Day, as Ukraine war rages on



JON RICHARDSON

Russia has dramatically scaled back its annual Victory Day parade in Red Square on May 9, with no heavy military hardware for the first time in 20 years. There will also be fewer foreign and Russian dignitaries present.

In addition, the government has shut down airports and temporarily suspended mobile internet access ahead of the holiday.

The Kremlin says the security measures are intended to guard against Ukrainian “terrorism”. It has declared a unilateral “truce” for May 8-9, warning that any Ukrainian attacks during the celebrations could trigger a massive strike on Kyiv. Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelensky has rejected the proposal, calling it a “theatrical performance”.

As the war grinds on in Ukraine, the Kremlin's precautions at home are remarkable - a sign that Ukraine's long-range strike capabilities have punctured one of Russian President Vladimir Putin's most important political rituals, as well as the country's seeming impregnability to the war.

Ukraine's momentum

Under Putin's rule, Victory Day has become more than just a commemoration of the Soviet defeat of Nazi Germany. The parade, a showcase of Russian military might, has been elevated into a core ritual for legitimising his regime.

The symbolism has taken on even greater meaning since Russia's full-scale invasion of Ukraine in 2022. The defeat of Nazi Germany has been fused with Putin's bogus claim that Russia needs to defeat fictitious Nazis in Ukraine.

Last year, Putin welcomed two dozen world leaders, including Xi Jinping of China, Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva of Brazil, Nicolás Maduro of Venezuela and Abdel Fattah el-Sisi of Egypt.

It was seen as an attempt to project Russia's global power and show that the West's attempts to isolate Moscow were failing.

Russian S-400 anti-aircraft missile system launchers displayed during the Victory Day military parade in Moscow on May 9, 2025. Alexander Zemlianichenko/AP

What a difference a year makes.

Ukraine has steadily expanded its ability to hit targets deep inside Russia, including oil terminals, refineries, military infrastructure and defence industries. Some targets in the Baltic Sea near St. Petersburg and in the Ural Mountains are hundreds of kilometres from Ukraine. The mere threat of drones has prompted dozens of airport closures and hun-



Ukraine's defence industrial base is a major part of the story. Kyiv says its capacity has grown 50-fold since 2022 and now accounts for 70 per cent of its weapons procurement



dreds of flight delays in recent months, especially in Moscow. At the same time, Ukraine has become much more adept at repelling Russian drone attacks on its own territory, reportedly shooting down 33,000 Russian drones in March this year alone — a record for one month.

The expansion of its unmanned ground robotic systems and deep-strike capabilities - including its Flamingo missile, which hit a defence plant 1,500 kilometres from Ukraine on May 5 — has helped Ukraine offset its disadvantages in manpower (which remains a major constraint) and ammunition.

Ukraine's defence industrial base is a major part of the story. Kyiv says its capacity has grown 50-fold since 2022 and now accounts for 70% of its weapons procurement.

Its successes have won the admiration of its European partners and others around the world. In recent days, for example, it signed a 10-year defence export deal with Saudi Arabia, the United Arab Emirates and Qatar, all three of which were attacked by Iran.

And there are signs Ukraine is gaining momentum on the frontlines. Analysts say Ukrainian forces actually gained more territory than they lost in February, for the first month since 2023.

Estimates of Russian death tolls are difficult to verify, but NATO chief Mark Rutte said Russia is losing 30,000-35,000 soldiers per month, while Zelensky said 35,000 Russian troops were either killed or wounded in the month of March.

Cracks at home

Meanwhile, Putin has only grown more paranoid about a potential coup or assassination attempt involving drones. He has reportedly sharply reduced his movements, spends more time in bunkers, and is surrounded by tighter security.

Domestic strains are growing as well. Russia's rate of recruitment has begun to fall short of its battlefield losses. The quality of recruits has plummeted as well, with alcoholics reportedly being duped or pressured into signing up.

It is becoming harder to sustain recruitment without another politically risky mobilisation. That matters because Putin has long tried to convince Russians the war can be fought at a distance, without demanding too much from society at large.

Russia's economy is suffering too, from chronic labour shortages, negative growth, and high inflation and



interest rates. And there are increasing signs of discontent. One critic, Ilya Remeslo, a former Kremlin propagandist, publicly accused Putin of being a “war criminal”, for instance. He was arrested but, in a surprise move, was released after just 30 days and has vowed to continue his campaign against the Russian leader.

Gennady Zyuganov, the leader of Russia's Communist Party (loyal to Putin), has warned the country's faltering economy risks stoking a 1917-style revolution. And an anonymous former senior official wrote in The Economist that grumbling among the elite shows Putin is losing his grip on Russia. Rising popular anger has also been triggered by the tightening of controls on the internet, including WhatsApp and Telegram, aimed at curbing dissent and criticism.

It is too early to claim the war has turned decisively in Kyiv's favour. The current stalemate may prevail for some time.

But recent trends suggest Russia can no

longer assume it can simply outlast Ukraine through attrition. This may well cause Putin to adjust his calculations about peace talks and his unwavering pursuit of maximalist goals.

Despite US President Donald Trump's recent unfounded claim that Ukraine has been “militarily defeated”, Kyiv is more than holding its own. It continues to have Europe's backing as well, with the EU recently finalising a massive 90 billion euro (A\$145 billion) loan. As eminent strategic analyst Lawrence Freedman argues, Ukraine is succeeding by not losing. He argues Ukraine's “Micawber strategy” - hoping that something will turn up, like the character Wilkins Micawber in David Copperfield - could very well pay off.

(The writer is visiting fellow, Centre for European Studies, Australian National University)
Courtesy: The Conversation



FROM AGENDA COVER

Thalapathy storms...

There is the usual retinue of freebies like financial aid for women and unemployed youth, free annual medical check-ups, free LPG, loan waivers etc, that seems run-of-the-mill.

He even did the de rigueur temple run to assuage people of faith who could have had potential concerns owing to his belief systems. His youth-baiting beyond the “Starpower” was with quaint promises like a Ministry of Artificial Intelligence — whether that delivers as well as it sounds remains to be seen. He even showed political astuteness in courting and heeding Prashant Kishore's critical advice on going solo, as opposed



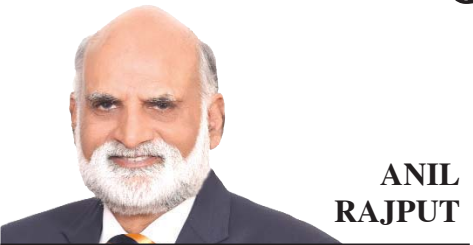
to tying up with any other regional or national party. Unlike the stuttering and seemingly confused positions of other cine stars like Kamal Haasan or Rajinikanth, Vijay has stunned all and sundry with his clarity, grit, and confidence in his chosen path.

For now, the masses have given him a solid benefit of doubt that has glossed over many personal, financial, cinematic, and even political controversies like the recent mishandling of his political rally that resulted in a deadly stampede. If anything the deployment of the state machinery to suppress his movement e.g., delayed clearance and supposed leak of his latest movie, Jana Nayagan, to

curbs on his political activities have all seemingly backfired as the Tamil electorate have given him a thumping endorsement to victory.

However Vijay would know better than most, that in real life the script rarely plays out as seamlessly, as it should. Film stars know the fickleness of stardom and how the fate of a star can never be taken for granted, as there is always yet another star waiting in the wings to dislodge the first. Today the masses are a lot more impatient, demanding, and seek action rather than words — that is particularly truer in the Southern States, where the overall socio-economic indices are higher than the national average. Vijay's much bandied cinematic line, Naa Vaaren (I am coming) has come true, now the stage is set for the more difficult path of leading the State of Tamil Nadu to its aspired destiny.

Savitri Puja: Where faith, food and family endure



ANIL
RAJPUT

Observed across many parts of Bharat under different names, Savitri Puja is among those sacred observances where faith is expressed through fasting, prayer and remembrance. Rooted in the timeless story of Savitri and Satyavan from the Mahabharata, the occasion honours a wife whose courage, intelligence and spiritual determination compelled even Yama, the lord of death, to restore her husband's life. Over generations, the observance has come to symbolise more than marital togetherness. It reflects steadfastness, duty, prayer and the moral strength of the household. Around this occasion evolved a distinctive culinary tradition as well, where fasting foods, seasonal fruits, simple sattvic preparations and ceremonial offerings became part of the custom and atmosphere of the day.

The story of Savitri and Satyavan gives the festival its moral depth. In the Mahabharata, Savitri is born to King Ashwapati after long prayer and is raised with strength of character and clarity of mind. When she chooses Satyavan as her husband, she does so despite being warned that he is destined to die within a year. Satyavan is no ordinary figure in the tale. He is the son of Dyumatsena, a blind and exiled king living in the forest after losing his kingdom. Savitri therefore accepts not only Satyavan, but also the hardship that surrounds his life. On the foretold day, she undertakes a rigorous fast and accompanies him into the forest, where he grows weak while cutting wood and rests his head in her lap. As his destined hour arrives, Yama, the divine lord of death and guardian of departed souls, comes to claim Satyavan's life. Savitri does not collapse in grief. She follows Yama and speaks to him with composure, wisdom and moral force. One by one, she secures boons for her father-in-law's sight, his lost kingdom, her father's lineage and finally her own future as Satyavan's wife. By the logic of this final boon, Satyavan's life must be restored. The banyan tree, or vat vriksha, later became an important symbol of this observance because of its association with long life, shelter and continuity.

The importance of the festival lies in the way this epic episode moved from scripture into lived household practice. Savitri Puja allows the story to be remembered through fasting, offerings, worshipping banyan

trees, seasonal foods and family rituals. It transforms Savitri's journey into a recurring cultural lesson on courage, presence of mind and the quiet strength with which women have shaped the moral life of the home.

While Savitri Puja is observed across different parts of the country, its rituals and modes of celebration vary from region to region. The festival assumes different names, ceremonial forms and degrees of social prominence depending on local customs, ritual calendars, culinary traditions and inherited community practices. In Odisha it is celebrated as Savitri or Sabitri Brata, in Bihar and parts of North India as Vat Savitri Vrat, in Maharashtra and Gujarat as the related observance of Vat Purnima, and in parts of Bengal through related observances linked to Savitri Chaturdashi. Some emphasise banyan-tree worship, others fasting disciplines and household offerings, yet all remain rooted in the enduring story of Savitri and Satyavan. What binds these traditions together is a shared reverence for endurance, self-control, prayer, family continuity and the moral strength of women within the household.

Food on Savitri Puja observes these sentiments through humility, simplicity and inherited practice. Fasting is generally observed in the early part of the day and is usually followed by fruits and sattvic preparations. A brass thali filled with ripe mangoes, bananas, soaked grains, flowers, vermilion and sacred thread is readied for the vrat and placed as an offering. It becomes part of the festival's beauty, reminding the household that food is first offered, then received as nourishment, and only afterwards enjoyed.

Odisha offers one of the richest culinary spreads, while in many northern and western communities the emphasis remains on fruits, coconut, simple sattvic foods and post-vrat nourishment. Among the most distinctive savoury offerings is muga chakata, a simple preparation of soaked green gram that reflects the quiet culinary spirit of the vrat. It is usually made from soaked or lightly sprouted whole green moong dal mixed with banana, coconut, sometimes jaggery, black pepper, or other fasting ingredients, then mashed into a sattvic preparation. Alongside it, soaked chana or buta (in Odia) is sometimes eaten plain, sometimes lightly mixed with coconut, ginger and a touch of salt after the fast is broken. Arwa rice, also used as a ceremonial grain, appears in ritual settings as a sign of auspiciousness and sustenance. These



are not elaborate dishes, yet they show that the meal begins with the simplest forms of sustenance.

On completion of the fast, many households move toward light vegetarian meals. Chudadahi, made with flattened rice softened in curd, is cooling, quick to prepare, and often enriched with banana, grated coconut, jaggery or small pieces of mango. In some homes, kheera-dahi, or cucumber mixed with curd, offers similar relief from the heat. Pakhala, the beloved fermented or water-soaked rice, may also be consumed after rituals, served with curd, roasted cumin, salt, green chilli and simple accompaniments. Its character makes it especially suited to the season, as it restores the body gently after the fast.

A more complete vegetarian spread often includes dalma, the Odia preparation in which lentils and vegetables are cooked together with minimal spice. Raw banana, pumpkin, papaya, brinjal, drumstick and colocasia may be added, depending on what is available. Tempered with cumin, dry red chilli and ghee, and finished with grated coconut in some versions, dalma carries the dignity of everyday food elevated for a special day. It occupies an important place in Odia festive, temple and community food culture, valued for being wholesome, balanced and easy to digest. Kanika, a mildly sweet fragrant rice cooked with ghee, bay leaf, cinnamon, cardamom, cashew and raisins, may appear in festive Odia meals, offering a bridge between savoury rice and sweet pulao. Ghuguni, made from soaked yellow peas or dried white peas simmered with ginger, cumin, turmeric and a light masala, provides a heartier savoury note. When served with puri or luchi after the vrat, it becomes a family dish that gathers people around the table after the long quiet of fasting.

In Bihar and parts of North India, the post-vrat meal often remains simple, built around fruits, curd, soaked gram, light potato preparations and cooling foods suited to the

summer season. In many north Indian homes, vrat-friendly aloo jeera is prepared with boiled potatoes, cumin, rock salt, green chilli and ghee, avoiding onion and garlic. Sabudana khichdi, made from soaked tapioca pearls tossed with roasted peanuts, potato, cumin and coriander, offers energy while remaining light. Singhara puri or kuttu puri, made from water chestnut or buckwheat flour, may be prepared where grain restrictions are observed, usually eaten with curd or a mild potato curry. In Maharashtra and Gujarat, where the related observance is often known as Vat Purnima, the culinary emphasis may remain more restrained, with fasting, fruits, coconut offerings and simple family foods carrying the meaning of the day. The vow remains consistent, but the plate changes with language, climate, agriculture and family tradition.

No account of Savitri Puja cuisine can be complete without its sweets, because they mark the emotional release of the vrat. Kheer, prepared by slowly simmering rice in milk until it thickens, then sweetening it with sugar or jaggery and flavouring it with cardamom, is among the most familiar offerings. In some homes, makhana kheer replaces rice with fox nuts roasted lightly in ghee before being cooked in milk. The dish is soft, cooling and auspicious, making it suitable for a day centred on prayer. Malpua, made from a batter of flour, milk, fennel and sometimes banana, fried gently and dipped in sugar syrup, brings a richer festive note. It is not always a fasting food, but after the rituals it becomes part of the family's celebratory table.

Odisha's pitha tradition gives Savitri Puja another layer of regional richness. Manda pitha, made from a rice flour casing filled with coconut and jaggery, is steamed until soft and fragrant. Kakara pitha is more robust, made with semolina or wheat dough, stuffed with coconut and jaggery, then fried until golden. Arisa pitha, prepared from rice flour and jaggery and fried slowly, has a deeper flavour and longer keeping quality, which makes it suitable for festive sharing. These sweets are not simply desserts. They carry the imprint of the household through recipes handed down by grandmothers, prepared carefully and shared with family and friends.

Seasonal fruits remain central even when elaborate dishes are prepared. Mango is perhaps the most visible fruit, not only because it ripens during the season but because its sweetness feels like a blessing in itself. Jackfruit, with its honeyed fragrance and many seeded bulbs, represents abundance besides being readily available in the eastern states. Banana brings softness and satiety, coconut purity and completeness, while palm fruit and date palm offer relief in the summer heat. Kendu, pineapple, apple and other fruits may also be included depending on region and availability. Fruit chaat, made after the puja with chopped mango, banana, apple, pomegranate, cucumber, grated coconut and lime, becomes an easy way to share the offered fruits among family members. Served with rock salt, chaat masala and lime, it is favoured for its sweet and tangy conclusion to a nutritious meal. In some homes, panchamrit, made

with milk, curd, honey, ghee and sugar or banana, is also prepared for offering to deities and later distributed as prasada. Each ingredient carries ritual meaning within Hindu thought, making the preparation both simple and deeply symbolic.

While non-vegetarian dishes are included in some households, they belong to the later family meal and not to the vrat or puja thali. Non-vegetarian dishes are not treated as offerings to Savitri. However, in some eastern Indian households, especially where fish is a normal part of the regional diet, the family meal after the fast may include fish or meat once the formal ritual has concluded. A light machha besara, prepared with fish cooked in mustard paste, turmeric and green chilli, can appear as a post-puja household dish in Odia or Bengali-influenced kitchens. Macher jhol, a thin fish curry with potato, tomato, cumin and turmeric, offers a gentler alternative that pairs well with rice. Chingri malai curry, made with prawns simmered in coconut milk and mild spices, may be reserved for a more festive meal, while chicken jhol, cooked as a light curry rather than a heavy restaurant-style dish, can be prepared for family members who are not fasting or for the evening meal after observance. This distinction protects the sanctity of the vrat while acknowledging the diversity of regional food habits.

The beverages associated with the season of Savitri Puja deserve a special mention because the festival falls during a hot period and the body needs cooling drinks after fasting. Pana, made with water, jaggery or sugar, curd or milk, fruit pulp, grated coconut, black pepper and sometimes chhena, is one of the most culturally resonant summer beverages in Odisha. Aam panna, prepared from boiled raw mango, cumin, black salt and jaggery, restores salt and sharpness after the heat of the day. Bel sherbet, made from the pulp of wood apple mixed with water and jaggery, is valued for its cooling nature. Chaas, or spiced buttermilk, brings curd, roasted cumin and rock salt together in a simple drink that settles the stomach. Sattu sharbat, made by mixing roasted gram flour with water, lemon, salt or jaggery, gives strength without heaviness. Tender coconut water, sugarcane juice, lemon sherbet and light fruit drinks made from mango, watermelon or bael also fit naturally into the day's refreshments. These beverages reflect the seasonal wisdom of the festival and help devotees remain hydrated through the long summer day.

The cuisine of Savitri Puja thus moves from a personal vow to shared nourishment. The morning belongs to fasting, prayer, offerings and family rituals. The evening opens into fruits, pulses, curd, rice, sweets and, in some households, a fuller regional meal. The festival does not seek meaning from excess. It asks food to remain sincere, seasonal and suited to a moment of prayer. I believe it teaches that the kitchen, like the shrine, can preserve values across generations.

In that sense, Savitri Puja is not only a celebration of Savitri's love for Satyavan, but also a reminder of how the household has served as one of Bharat's most enduring civilisational institutions. Its cuisine gathers the sacred and the seasonal into one graceful observance, where fasting, offerings, fruits, grains, sweets, cooling drinks and carefully prepared family dishes become more than food. They become carriers of memory, responsibility and cultural continuity. I believe this is where the deeper lesson of Savitri Puja lies. Our civilisational heritage is preserved not only in temples, scriptures and public rituals, but also in the quiet practices of the home, in the food placed before the divine, in the stories retold across generations, and in the values that families continue to live through their daily customs.

(The writer is Secretary, Cuisine India Society)

Finding the boundary of AI era on Mother's Day

NISHANT SAHDEV

There is a spine-broken diary on the granite counter of my family's Delhi kitchen. It is an ordinary object filled with slanted Hindi script and measurements making no mathematical sense. On a page detailing a Gajar ka Halwa recipe, there is a faded thumbprint. It is a stain from a drop of warm ghee that fell a decade ago, pressed into the paper by my mother's hurried thumb.

Beside that diary is my smartphone. Applications can photograph my mother's recipe, translate it into Mandarin, calculate its caloric breakdown, and generate a hyper-realistic video of a digital chef cooking it. I could take three minutes of her WhatsApp voice notes, feed them into a neural network, and have an AI archive her pitch and intonation forever. While this tech allows us to preserve our heritage with total fidelity, our obsession with AI's infinite capabilities is creating a dangerous blind spot in how we understand human love. We are confusing data preservation with devotion.

In the tech industry, we design systems with a singular goal: eliminating friction. We want processes to be seamless and perfectly efficient. But when we bring this mindset into our homes, we forget that an Indian mother's love is built entirely on friction.

When a mother spends three hours by a hot stove in the sweltering humidity of a summer afternoon, she is not executing a task a robotic arm could replicate. She spends a currency she can never earn back: her time, energy, and cellular youth. Every act of maternal devotion is a microscopic expenditure of her mortality, given willingly to fuel yours.

Viewing her labor as a mere optimization task blurs her sacrifice. While an AI model never fatigues, a mother has joints that ache with the



monsoon rains. Unlike AI, which consumes cheap computing power, a mother sets aside her ambitions to absorb the messy details of your heartbreak. She spends her life-a resource neither cheap nor renewable. As a generation of busy professionals, we often assuage our guilt of absence by throwing technology at the problem. We buy our parents smarter devices, set automated deliveries, and point high-definition cameras at them during Diwali. We think building an efficient digital infrastructure means loving them better.

But AI, for all its staggering brilliance, gives you the product of a mother without the cost. And the cost is what makes it love. As a physicist, I study the laws of thermodynamics and the inevitable decay of systems. We build intelligent machines to outsmart this decay, attempting to mathematically archive ourselves into eternity. As we wade into this



algorithmic age, we must draw a hard boundary. We do not need to resist Artificial Intelligence; we need to put it in its proper place.

The purpose of AI is not to simulate human connection, nor perfectly archive our mothers so we can comfortably ignore them while they are still here. Its true, revolutionary promise is giving us our time back.

This Mother's Day, let AI draft your emails. Let the algorithm manage your calendar and optimize your spreadsheets. Let the machine absorb the friction of the modern workplace so you can step away from your screens and back into the kitchen. Use the machine's ultimate efficiency to afford the beautiful inefficiency of being human. The most sacred artifacts of an Indian childhood are inherently imperfect.

It is the slight misalignment of a hastily applied bindi. It is the dal she forgets to salt because her mind is paralyzed with worry over your career. It is the way her voice cracks with tears when blessing you over a video call. These imperfections cannot be prompted by an LLM. You cannot engineer a hallucination of

genuine worry. These flaws are the friction of a human soul colliding with a difficult world, trying to shield you. Digitizing the recipe cleans up the archive, but you lose the ghee stain. You erase the messy, chaotic evidence that she was actually there, breathing, rushing, living, and loving you in real-time.

This Sunday, do not buy her a smarter gadget or send an AI-generated poem. Use the time technology saved you to sit across from her. Look at the lines around her eyes and recognize them as the physical receipts of the worry spent keeping you alive. Eat the food she made, knowing you will never taste this exact batch again. Listen to her voice, knowing the sound waves will permanently dissipate into the air.

Let AI handle the infinite. But let your mother be beautifully, fiercely, and painfully temporary. Because it is only when we accept that our time with her is a finite resource, that we finally understand the sheer magnitude of what she did with it.

(The writer is a theoretical physicist at the University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill)

Rekindling old Delhi's culinary soul

GYANESHWAR DAYAL

At a time when "modern Indian dining" often means deconstructing familiar dishes beyond recognition, Daryaganj Gold takes a refreshingly different route. It elevates North Indian cuisine without disturbing its soul. The newly launched flagship format of the Daryaganj brand in Aerocity is not merely a larger restaurant; it is an attempt to give classic North Indian food the scale, theatre, and dignity usually reserved for global fine-dining concepts.

The moment one enters the expansive 150-seater space, the intention is clear. Gold-plated tandoors glow in the open kitchen, chefs move with choreographed precision, and the mood balances old Delhi nostalgia with contemporary luxury. Yet, for all its polish, the restaurant never feels intimidating. Instead, it carries the warmth of a family celebration.

What makes Daryaganj Gold stand apart is that it resists the temptation to reinvent for the sake of novelty. Its celebrated Butter Chicken and Dal Makhani continue to anchor the experience, drawing from recipes linked to the legacy of Kundan Lal Jaggi. But the new Gold menu introduces thoughtful additions that surprise without alienating. The chaat selection is particularly inventive. Dahi Bhalla Bingsu and Mushroom Ram Ladoo reinterpret street-



food memory with finesse, while the Daulat Ki Chaat evokes the fleeting winter delicacy of Old Delhi with admirable delicacy.

The highlight, however, is the Five Senses Curries. The dish arrives not just as food, but as performance - the whistle of the cooker, the aroma escaping the lid, the slow reveal of deeply spiced gravy, and finally the tenderness of the meat. It captures what Co-Founder and CEO Amit Bagga calls "presenting familiar food in a contemporary and engaging way, without changing its soul."

Bagga's larger philosophy is visible throughout the restaurant. "Modern Indian dining in 2026 is not about changing the food, but about changing how it is experienced," he says. That idea defines Daryaganj Gold. It respects nostalgia but refuses to remain trapped within it.

The live chaat counters, chef theatre nights, unplugged music performances, and intimate private dining rooms all add layers to the experience. Yet, the real triumph is simpler: beneath the glamour, the food still comforts. In a city crowded with fashionable dining experiments, Daryaganj Gold succeeds because it remembers that memory itself can be luxurious.

OLD DELHI
NOSTALGIA FINDS
CONTEMPORARY
EXPRESSION



Nobody Can Really Hurt You

If someone has used harsh words with you, but with good intention, you can only thank them. You have only grown stronger by their act

GURUDEV SRI SRI RAVI SHANKAR

When you feel hurt, you blame others for causing it. But the truth is, it is not people who hurt us. It is our own mind, our own vulnerability and our own emotions that entangle us and make us feel hurt.

If you really look into it, what causes the hurt? Somebody's words, somebody's selfishness, somebody not caring for you? What usually happens is you love somebody, and you think they do not care for you, or you have helped somebody a lot, and they do not talk to you, and that hurts you, does it not? Wake up and see: Is there an intention in them to hurt you? Place yourself in their shoes and try to look at things from their perspective too.

Often, you never intended to hurt someone, yet they feel hurt by your actions. What do you usually tell them? "I did not mean it, it just happened. I did not mean to hurt you, but an incident or event happened that gave you the idea that I hurt you."

Now, if you really intended to hurt somebody, it means you have a deep hurt inside you. Even then, you are worthy of being excused, and similarly, you have to excuse the other person as well.

If someone has hurt you intentionally, you should know that they are unwell. People hurt others out of a lack of wisdom, unhappiness or a lack of inner connection with the divine, and this keeps them mentally disturbed and dissatisfied. When someone is unwell, how can you get angry at them? In a mental hospital, there are so many people saying so many things. Do you get annoyed at them? You do not.

Someone happy, content and in love will not hurt anyone. It is simply impossible. If someone hurts another, it is because there is a deep wound or scar of pain and rejection inside them that needs to be healed. What should your attitude be towards someone who is unwell? You will naturally be compassionate towards them, and when compassion reaches its peak, it is nothing but love.

And if someone has not intended to hurt you, if it is an unintentional act, then it is a mistake on your part to blame them for your hurt. You can only blame your own perception, and not them. They are not culprits. Then it is you who has to ask them for forgiveness. Asking for forgiveness in such a situation can save the relationship. If someone has used harsh words with you, but with good intention, you can only thank them.

You have only grown stronger by their act. For example, no parent has raised their children without giving them a piece of their mind, have they? They may have used hurtful words, but it has been for your own good. If a friend has insulted you knowingly, you can only thank them. This is because they have dared to give you honesty, to give you what you needed to grow. Why would anyone want to hurt you at their own cost? Nobody wants to risk their friendship. What should be your attitude? "Thank you! You did something good for me. It has made me strong."

How you perceive situations around you is entirely in your hands. Any intention you put out there comes back to you. If you think that everyone is hurting you, your own intentions will create similar situations again and again. Wake up and see: "There is none other than the One, and the One



“TIME, MIND AND EVENTS ARE CLOSELY INTERLINKED, AND NONE OF THEM IS STAGNANT; THEY KEEP CHANGING. WHEN THE MIND IS STUCK TO EVENTS, THERE IS SUFFERING”
— GURUDEV



IF YOU REALLY LOOK INTO IT, WHAT CAUSES THE HURT? SOMEBODY'S WORDS, SOMEBODY'S SELFISHNESS, SOMEBODY NOT CARING FOR YOU? WHAT USUALLY HAPPENS IS YOU LOVE SOMEBODY, AND YOU THINK THEY DO NOT CARE FOR YOU, OR YOU HAVE HELPED SOMEBODY A LOT, AND THEY DO NOT TALK TO YOU, AND THAT HURTS YOU, DOES IT NOT?

comes to me in many forms. It is all for my growth, for my well-being, for my happiness." This is because the Universe is so loving and compassion-

ate towards you. If we keep this wisdom in our hearts, nobody can hurt us. In India, there is a proverb: If God is happy with you, He gives you a lot, and if He is very happy with you, He might slap you as well. When your senses are turned outwards and you get attached to material things, you invite pain and suffering. Problems come so that you can look within and enter a state of dispassion and calm. God creates situations to turn you away from this outward chase and brings you towards Himself. He wants to draw you to Himself so that you drop everything and look at Him. When the soul is united with the Divine, when there is no duality, you experience this innermost joy. Once that connection happens, nothing whatsoever in the universe can bring down your smile, energy, enthusiasm or joy. Everything is an opportunity for growth in life.

If you are happy and comfortable, it is an opportunity for you to recognise the truth and share it with others. If misery comes your way, make use of it as an opportunity to turn inwards, become very strong from within and recognise the truth of the Universe - that everything is changing and every relationship is fleeting.

Usually, we tend to let go of pleasant emotions and hold on to unpleasant ones. But when the mind becomes free and cultured through meditation, this tendency to hold on to negative emotions is the first thing that disappears. We start living in the moment. Little things cease to bother you. Every up and down that comes your way makes this recurrent play of life more interesting.

Time, mind and events are closely interlinked, and none of them is stagnant; they keep changing. When the mind is stuck to events, there is suffering. When the mind flows with time, it is fresh and alive.

A Millennium Monument of Harmony: The Abu Dhabi Hindu Mandir

Rising from the desert of Abu Dhabi, this BAPS Hindu Mandir Abu Dhabi stands as a rare symbol of unity in a divided world. A timeless gift to the modern age by the revered Mahant Swami Maharaj, it embodies a vision far beyond stone and structure. More than a place of worship, it reflects love, peace, non-violence and harmony between nations, faiths and cultures. In a land shaped by diverse traditions, it redefines coexistence with quiet dignity and universal truth. A true millennium monument, it reminds humanity that the deepest values of faith can build bridges stronger than borders



DR GYANANANDDAS SWAMI

Across years, decades and even centuries, most days pass without distinction. The sun rises and sets, and life moves forward in familiar rhythms. But occasionally, a single day stands apart, marked by an event so significant that it earns a lasting place in history. These rare moments remind us that even within the ordinary flow of time, something extraordinary can redefine the future.

One such moment unfolded on 14 February 2024. The dawn over Abu Dhabi, in the United Arab Emirates, carried an unusual radiance. The vast skies of the Middle East bore witness to a day of quiet grandeur, as the desert sands of Arabia seemed transformed from barren stretches into landscapes of spiritual meaning. It was the inauguration of the first and largest Hindu mandir in the Middle East, built using traditional Indian craftsmanship, a landmark that turned vision into reality.

At precisely 8 a.m., within the newly constructed, magnificent BAPS Hindu Mandir Abu Dhabi rising proudly in Abu Dhabi, the sacred ceremony of murti-pratishtha (consecration of deities) commenced. The air resonated with Vedic chants, broadcast live across the globe, echoing through homes and hearts worldwide.

This was an unprecedented event in world history. The very idea of creating a grand symbol of Hindu civilisation and culture on land associated with Islamic heritage once belonged to the realm of imagination. Yet, it stood realised. In doing so, the mandir emerged as a bridge of harmony, bringing together leaders such as the UAE's royal authority, Mohamed bin Zayed Al Nahyan, and India's esteemed Prime Minister Narendra Modi on a shared platform, bound not by politics but by mutual respect and

trust. Such a convergence is nothing short of transformative, an event marking the dawn of a new era.

It is this very spirit of unity that resonated across the world. Across nations, religions, societies and languages, words like love, brotherhood, harmony, coexistence and dialogue are often spoken, but too often remain abstract ideals. This mandir has given those words a living voice and tangible meaning.

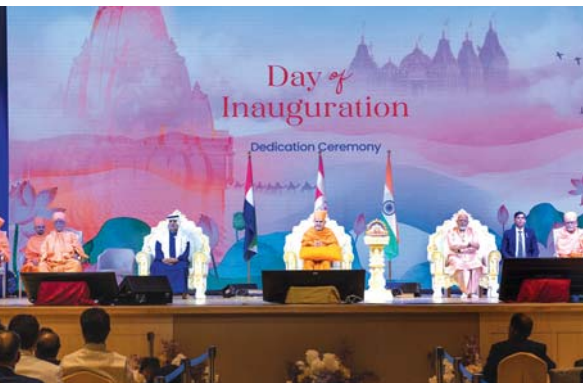
Walking upon the earth is ordinary; yet when a human steps onto the moon, the world takes notice. But every such achievement begins long before the moment itself, with a

TRUE ACHIEVEMENTS,
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dream, sustained by faith, that quietly sows the seeds of greatness. As Prime Minister Narendra Modi himself recalled in his speech on the day of inauguration, "The magnificent mandir that we see today in Abu Dhabi is because it was first envisioned years ago (in 1997) by Pramukh Swami Maharaj."

Every great achievement rests on a strong foundation. In this case, the guiding force was the revered guru Pramukh Swami Maharaj, whose vision became the source of inspiration for the mandir. Yet, a long journey still lay ahead. Sustained effort and decisive action were essential to carry that dream to completion.

True achievements, after all, are not written merely in ink, but in rare acts of dedication and determination, which come together to create history.



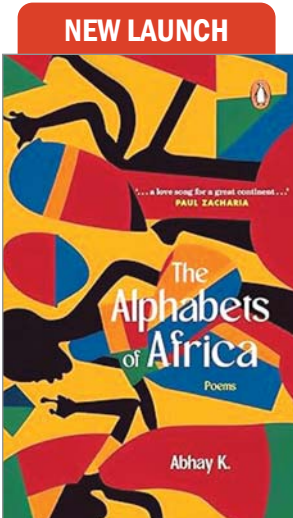
(The writer Dr Swami Gyanananddas is a dedicated follower of the Swaminarayan tradition and has earned a PhD from MS University)

Breaking the African stereotypes

GYANESHWAR DAYAL

The launch and reading of *The Alphabets of Africa* by Abhay K was not merely a literary event at Oxford book store in Connaught place in Delhi — it was an act of re-seeing a continent long trapped in narrow narratives. The occasion brought together literature, diplomacy, and lived experience in a rare confluence. Abhay K, who has served as a diplomat in Madagascar and now represents India as Ambassador to Azerbaijan, spoke not as an observer of Africa but as someone who has encountered it intimately. The interactive session with Murtaza Ali Khan and Amit Singh was informative and as well as a rare peep into the continent we know so little about yet think we know everything about it — Africa.

At the reading, passages from the book revealed its distinctive voice-lyrical yet informed, poetic yet grounded in history. The poems move alphabetically, each letter opening a window into a dif-



Title: The Alphabets of Africa
Author: Abhay K
MRP: ₹499
Publisher: Vintage Classics

ferent facet of Africa — its landscapes, civilisations, icons, and everyday rhythms. This structure, deceptively simple, becomes a powerful narrative device, turning the book into what critics have described as a "cartography of a continent" told through verse.

What makes *Alphabets of Africa* stand apart is its deliberate departure from the dominant, often reductive imagination of Africa. For decades, global narratives have flattened the continent into a trilogy of stereotypes-wildlife, poverty, and conflict. Abhay K challenges this framing head-on. His poems foreground Africa as the cradle of humanity, a land of ancient civilisations, intellectual traditions, and cultural innovations that have shaped the world.

During the launch, the author underscored a striking idea: that every human being carries Africa within them. This is not poetic exaggeration but a reminder of scientific and historical reality-that human origins trace back to the continent. By weaving such insights into verse, the book bridges knowledge and emotion, transforming facts into felt experience.

The collection draws extensively from the author's travels across Africa, lending it authenticity that goes beyond second-hand observation. It introduces readers

to figures and histories often absent from mainstream discourse-emperors, queens, resistance leaders, artists, and everyday cultural practices. From the wealth of Mansa Musa to the resilience of Yaa Asantewaa, from ancient treaties to living traditions, the poems reclaim a narrative that is both diverse and deeply rooted.

The *Alphabets of Africa* refuses to romanticise Africa while also rejecting colonial stereotypes that once reduced the continent to a "heart of darkness". Instead, Abhay K presents a layered portrayal that acknowledges both struggle and splendour, giving the work emotional depth and intellectual credibility.

The reading session encouraged audiences to question inherited perceptions and engage with Africa as a living, evolving reality. More than poetry, the book becomes a bridge across histories and cultures, reminding readers that Africa is central to understanding humanity itself.

Ram, poetry and the human spirit

TEAM AGENDA

Ashutosh Agnihotri, while illuminating the collective consciousness of Indian culture, spiritual traditions and civilisational values, emerges as a devoted traveller through the emotional and philosophical landscape of Sab Par Ram Tapasvi Raja. Written in fluid Hindi verse and lyrical expression, this poetic work deserves to be read not merely as literature, but as a profound exploration of the humane, cultural and national dimensions of Shri Ram's character.

Carrying forward the epic tradition into modern Hindi poetry, the poet presents contemporary interpretations of several episodes from the Ramcharitmanas. Passages such as the "Shiv-Parvati dialogue" and the celebrated "Dhanush Yagya" are rendered with freshness and emotional resonance, offering readers a renewed understanding of these timeless episodes.

The lines: "Haan Ram

nahin hai saadhan,
Shiv ka hai aadhar priya,
Jo mere andar dikhta hai
wahi to Ram hai... beautifully capture the spiritual essence of the collection.

Throughout the book, the reader encounters not only devotion and surrender, but also moments of nationalism, moral introspection and deep human sensitivity. Whether exploring Kaikeyi and Sita's inner dilemmas, Bharat's selfless sacrifice, or the emotional devastation surrounding Mandodari's grief, the poet consistently brings forth a spiritual voice that resonates amid human suffering and ethical conflict.

The emotional strength of the poetry lies in its ability to connect devotional philosophy with contemporary human concerns. The poet's lines flow with rhythm and musicality, often carrying the cadence of compositions meant for theatrical or artistic performance.

The language remains expressive yet accessible, never weighed down by excessive ornamentation;

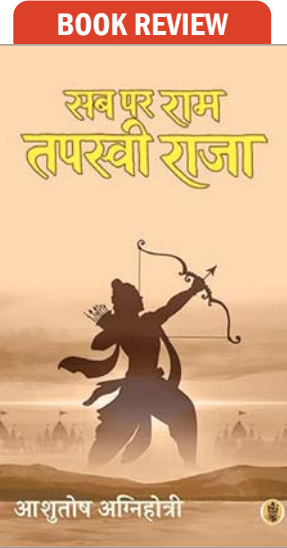
instead, it allows the emotional core of each episode to emerge naturally and powerfully. Although rooted in tradition, the poetry sustains a distinctly modern sensibility.

Ram is presented not merely as a divine figure, but as a symbol of ethical consciousness, sacrifice, compassion and cultural unity. References to Shabari's devotion, Bharat's renunciation and the ideals of Rajdharm deepen the philosophical texture of the collection.

Read through the lens of Indian poetics, the work evokes an aesthetic space where poetic beauty and spiritual experience merge seamlessly. The poet's ability to internalise Shabari's longing, Kaikeyi's remorse, Bharat's sacrifice and Ram's ideals of governance lends the collection emotional depth and dramatic vitality.

Ultimately, *Sab Par Ram Tapasvi Raja* emerges as a meaningful and enduring poetic work- one that holds relevance not only for

readers of devotional literature, but also for theatre practitioners, performing artists and wider cultural discourse for years to come.



Title: Sab Par Ram
Tapasvi Raja
Author: Ashutosh Agnihotri
MRP: ₹495
Publisher: Radhakrishna
Prakashan Pvt. Ltd., Delh